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Faculty of Regional Development and International Studies



The Foreign Policy of the Czech Republic on Genocide: A Case Study of the Srebrenica Genocide

Bachelor thesis

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Eliška Císařová

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LIST OF ABBREVIATIONS

BIH	Bosnia and Herzegovina
EP	European Parliament
EU	European Union
ICC	International Criminal Court
ICJ	International Court of Justice
ICTY	International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia
IRMCT	International Residual Mechanism for Criminal Tribunals
ISIS	Islamic State of Iraq and Syria
NATO	North Atlantic Treaty Organization
NGOs	Non-Governmental Organizations
R2P	Responsibility to Protect
SDS	Serb Democratic Party
UN	United Nations
UNPROFOR	United Nations Protection Force
VRS	Army of Republika Srpska

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INTRODUCTION

This bachelor's thesis analyzes the foreign policy of the Czech Republic toward the Srebrenica genocide. The genocide, which occurred in July 1995 during the Bosnian War, is characterized by the systematic execution of over 8,000 Bosniak males by forces of the Republika Srpska. (Hoare, 2021) It not only exposed the weaknesses of international institutions in preventing mass atrocities but also left a lasting impact on how states, including the Czech Republic, approach issues of genocide, justice, and international responsibility. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025) The diplomatic discourse surrounding genocide has since become a key component of foreign policy formulations, reflecting moral considerations and geopolitical interests.

The goal of this thesis is to examine the evolution of the Czech Republic's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide from 1995 to 2025, and to analyze how domestic political transformations, historical experiences, and international developments influenced Czech diplomatic discourse and actions. The thesis focuses on how the Czech Republic's position has increasingly come to align with that of the European Union, particularly as the EU has placed greater emphasis on human rights and transitional justice in its foreign policy (Eurojust, 2014). In this light, the Srebrenica case offers valuable insight into how memory politics and diplomacy interact in a post-communist European state.

The author of this thesis chose the Srebrenica genocide as a case study as it stands among the gravest mass atrocities in Europe since World War II and has been officially classified as genocide under international law. (United Nations General Assembly, 2024) In today's world, where violence and hatred are once again on the rise, it is essential to protect human dignity and learn from past atrocities. Current crises in regions like Tigray in Ethiopia, Darfur in Sudan, Ukraine, and the Middle East, demonstrate that the warning signs of mass atrocities are still very much present. Governments must respond quickly and firmly to defend basic human rights and prevent such atrocities from happening again.

1. METHODS AND AIMS

1.1 Goal of the thesis

The goal of this thesis is to analyze the Czech Republic's foreign policy on genocide, with a specific focus on the Srebrenica genocide. By addressing the research questions, this study aims to trace the evolution of Czech foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide over the past three decades and to examine the key historical, political, and international factors that have influenced this shift.

Furthermore, the thesis seeks to place the Czech Republic's foreign policy within a broader international context, particularly as a member of the European Union, to consider its role as a smaller European state adapting to global norms of transitional justice and genocide recognition. Through comparative analysis, this case study aims to assess the extent to which Czech foreign policy aligns with the official position of the EU regarding the Srebrenica genocide.

The theoretical part of this bachelor's thesis builds on previous research examining the theoretical definition of genocide, and the policy frameworks of Czechia and the European Union on genocide. It also explores the broader context of the Bosnian War that led to the Srebrenica massacre. This theoretical framework forms the basis for the following analysis of the Czech Republic's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide and its comparison with that of the European Union.

1.2 Research questions

The main research question that the author focuses on is:

- *How has the Czech Republic's perception of the Srebrenica genocide evolved in its official statements and diplomatic actions from 1995 to 2025?*

Additional research questions that aim to understand the broader context are:

- *Which historical, political, and international factors influenced the Czech Republic's perception and diplomatic approach to the Srebrenica genocide?*
- *To what extent does Czech foreign policy on the Srebrenica genocide align with or diverge from the position of the European Union?*

1.3 Methodology

This thesis employs a qualitative case study approach to examine how the Czech Republic's foreign policy discourse on the Srebrenica genocide has evolved between 1995 and 2025. This method allows for a thorough exploration of the topic within its broader international and historical context (Crowe et al., 2011). By focusing on a specific event, the case study provides deeper insight into how Czech diplomacy engages with the complex and sensitive issue of genocide. It enables the researcher to closely analyze real-world developments and understand their underlying dynamics in detail (Yin, 2018).

The theoretical part builds on insights gathered from existing literature. A literature review involves examining, evaluating, and bringing together existing research on a specific topic or area of study. (Chigbu et al, 2023). The author uses a literature review to define the concept of genocide, examine the Czech Republic's foreign policy on genocide and responses to past genocides, as well as the EU's stance on genocide. The goal is to present a clear and objective overview of existing research. The author drew on data from databases of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, European Commission, and the United Nations databases. Additionally, the research draws on scholarly articles from academic databases or books, such as Gabela, Maloku (*Genocid: Fundamental Aspects of Understanding, Comprehending and Investigating Crime*, 2023) or Jones (*Genocide: A Comprehensive Introduction*, 2010).

In the empirical part of the thesis, the author applies the method of secondary data analysis, which enables her to evaluate and identify changes in the Czech Republic's approach to the Srebrenica genocide over thirty years. Secondary data analysis is the process of analyzing data gathered by others to examine fresh research angles or explore new perspectives (Johnston, 2014). The author used materials written in Czech, English, and Bosnian. The source of data comes from official statements by the International Criminal Court, Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, the European Parliament, and relevant United Nations materials. The author also consulted media sources to gain a clearer understanding of the diplomatic actions presented. These include Czech Television and Bosnian media outlets such as Fokus.ba, N1 Sarajevo, and Preporod.info. Additionally, the research draws on scholarly articles accessed through academic databases like ResearchGate and Scopus.

During a two-month internship in March and April 2025 at the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law, University of Sarajevo, the author conducted field research in Bosnia and Herzegovina. During this research, the author visited important sites, including the *Siege of Sarajevo Museum* and the *Srebrenica Memorial Center in Potočari*. These visits offered important direct perspectives on the genocide and significantly influenced the main arguments developed in the thesis.

The author also conducted three semi-structured interviews. Purposive sampling, a technique where participants are intentionally selected based on their relevance to the research objectives (Palinkas et al., 2015), was used to choose experts with direct or institutional experience related to the thesis' topic. The author selected respondents from academia, the diplomatic sphere, and the Srebrenica Memorial Center to ensure a diverse range of perspectives on Czech foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide. Each person was asked questions based on their expertise to gather relevant insights. All respondents signed a document stating how their insights will be used and who can access this thesis.

- a) The first semi-structured interview was conducted with Prof. Dr. Ermin Kuka, an academic from the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law in Sarajevo. Due to language barriers, the interview was conducted in English via email between April 5th and May 6th, 2025. Prof. Kuka shared valuable insights from a Bosnian institutional perspective, particularly on how the Czech and EU governments collaborate with Bosnian research institutions on the topic of the Srebrenica genocide. He also addressed questions about cultural and educational exchanges between the countries and highlighted the importance of the international community.
- b) The second semi-structured interview was conducted with Ing. Josef Zrzavecký, the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina. The author conducted the interview in person at the Czech Embassy in Sarajevo on April 16th, 2025, in the Czech language. Mr. Zrzavecký provided valuable information that supported findings about the Czech Republic's involvement and changes in addressing the Srebrenica genocide. He also discussed the country's alignment with EU policies and introduced upcoming Czech government initiatives in education and development regarding Srebrenica. This interview was not recorded, the author conducted

handwritten notes. The interview with the Deputy Ambassador was later translated into English.

- c) The third interview was conducted with Mr. Azir Osmanović, the Director of the Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari. The interview was conducted in English via email between April 7th and 20th, 2025, due to a lack of respondent's availability for a personal meeting. Mr. Osmanović provided important information about Czech and EU government's visit to the Srebrenica Memorial center and cemetery, Czech and EU educational efforts, and commented on the Czech ambassador and cooperation with the Czech and EU embassies.

The data from interviews were collected and modified in three steps:

- a) **Transcription** – first, the author transcribed the handwritten notes from the in-person interview, while leaving the email responses unchanged
- b) **Translation** – the author translated the interview conducted in Czech into English, while keeping the two interviews conducted initially in English unchanged
- c) **Open coding** – the transcribed and translated interviews were divided into seven sections, which were later marked by codes indicating the main topics and key points

The author identified these key codes:

- a) Czechia's perception of Srebrenica genocide
- b) Education and academic cooperation
- c) Current political and security challenges in Bosnia
- d) Diplomatic visits and symbolic gestures
- e) Czech-EU alignment and differences
- f) International justice
- g) Czech and EU perspectives on the 2024 UN General Assembly resolution concerning Srebrenica.

The author organized the interview findings into three main categories: changes in Czechia's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide; the historical, political, and international factors shaping Czechia's position; and the extent to which Czech and EU policies are aligned.

Furthermore, a comparative analysis of Czech and European Union discourse was undertaken to assess areas of alignment and divergence regarding the recognition of the Srebrenica genocide. A comparative analysis is a multidisciplinary research method that systematically compares two or more subjects to identify similarities, differences, and patterns (Blair-Walcott, 2023). The author chose seven categories and compared the Czech Republic's response with that of the EU. The seven categories include: response to 1995 events, 10th anniversary of Srebrenica massacre, 20th anniversary of Srebrenica massacre, year 2024 – UN General Assembly resolution, recognition of genocide, international criminal courts, and a section about education and memory. The author chose these categories to compare EU's and Czech involvement in critical moments like genocide recognition, anniversaries, justice, and education in order to present a bigger picture of the alignment. This comparison places the Czech Republic's actions in a wider international context and highlights how its foreign policy reflects global norms on human rights and responses to genocide.

1.4 Benefits of the thesis

This thesis examines how the Czech Republic's foreign policy approach to genocide has evolved over time, with a particular focus on the Srebrenica genocide. It explores how domestic political changes, the role of historical memory, and international commitments have shaped the country's diplomatic responses over the past three decades. By placing Czech foreign policy within a wider European context, the thesis sheds light on how small and medium-sized states navigate their moral responsibilities in international organizations and respond to the challenges posed by genocide in today's interconnected world.

One of the key strengths of this research lies in its practical, hands-on approach. Together with the analysis of official documents and academic sources, the author conducted original fieldwork, including visits to key museums and interviews with the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic, a university-based researcher, and the Director of the Srebrenica Memorial Center. Each of these conversations brought valuable perspectives that enriched the study. Since this topic remains largely underexplored in the context of Czech foreign policy, the thesis aims to fill part of that gap. Its findings offer a historical perspective on how the Czech Republic has dealt with issues of genocide and may inform future diplomatic and legal discussions.

1.5 Thesis structure

The author structured the thesis into eight chapters with several subchapters. The first chapter explains the methodology, states the main aim of the thesis, outlines the research questions, and describes how the study contributes to the topic. Chapters 2 to 5 form the theoretical part of the thesis, providing the theoretical framework for understanding genocide, examining the Czech and European Union policy frameworks on genocide, and offering historical context for the Bosnian War. This thesis concludes with an analysis of the events that led to the Srebrenica massacre.

Chapters 6 to 8 build the empirical part of this study, each addressing one of the research questions under investigation. Chapter 6 analyzes the evolution of the Czech Republic's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide between 1995 and 2025. Chapter 7 examines the historical, political, and international factors influencing the Czech policy-making about Srebrenica. Chapter 8 compares the extent of alignment or divergence between the policies of the European Union and the Czech Republic, and provides a table to illustrate the key findings visually. The author strengthened the empirical section by including excerpts from interviews, which bring unique insight and add a valuable personal dimension to the research.

The thesis concludes by summarizing the main findings and offering a critical reflection through a final discussion and conclusion.

2. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK OF GENOCIDE

2.1 Definition of genocide

Raphael Lemkin, a Polish-Jewish lawyer, introduced and defined the concept of genocide in 1944, arguing that newly recognized crimes need their own specific terminology. He defined genocide as “the destruction of a nation or an ethnic group” and emphasized that it includes a range of actions, not just mass killing. According to Lemkin, genocide applies efforts to prevent births through abortion or sterilization, the intentional spread of disease, forced labor that leads to death in specialized camps, and the separation of families for deportation (Gabela, Maloku, 2023).

Building on Lemkin’s work, various institutions have developed more formal definitions. According to the European Commission: Migration and Home Affairs (n.d.), genocide is “an act committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group.”

Similarly, the United Nations (2024) defines genocide as having two core components: a mental element, the intent to eliminate a national, ethnic, racial, or religious group, and a physical element, consisting of five specific acts. These include: killing members of the group; causing serious physical or psychological harm; deliberately creating conditions that would lead to the group’s partial or total destruction; implementing measures to prevent births; and forcibly transferring children from the group to another. These actions fall under the legal definition of genocide under international law.

In addition to legal definitions, genocide has also been framed from a sociopolitical perspective. Rubinstein (2004) describes genocide as the deliberate mass killing of people simply because they belong to a particular group, most often ethnic or religious minorities. He points out that civilians, especially women, children, and the elderly, who should be protected by international law, are often the ones who suffer the most.

2.2 Genocide as a crime against humanity

Genocide is seen as the most extreme form of crime against humanity. Unlike other crimes against humanity, which involve large-scale or systematic attacks on civilians, genocide is

defined by a clear intent to eliminate an entire ethnic, racial, or religious group, either completely or in part. Courts only label such crimes as genocide when this intent is clearly proven. What sets genocide apart is that the violence is aimed not just at individuals, but at destroying the group itself. (Gabela, Maluku, 2023)

2.3 The United Nations Genocide Convention

The United Nations Genocide Convention (formally known as the “*Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide*”) was adopted in the aftermath of the Holocaust, precisely in 1948, as a legal response to the unprecedented atrocities of that era. It was intended as a legal instrument and a moral commitment by the global community’s responsibility to stop future large-scale atrocities. (Totten & Theriault, 2019) It represented a groundbreaking step in international law by recognizing genocide as a distinct and punishable crime prosecuted internationally (Jones, 2010).

In practice, the Convention requires all signatory states to treat genocide as a crime in their legal systems, to hold perpetrators accountable, and to work together with other countries to prevent and stop such acts. The document makes it clear that genocide is a violation of international law and highlights the need for global cooperation to put an end to it. The Convention requires that authorities bring individuals accused of genocide to trial either in national courts of the country where the crime took place or before an international tribunal, such as the International Criminal Court. (Gabela, Maluku, 2023)

The Convention includes 19 articles that define genocide, list related crimes, and set out how the treaty should be enforced and carried out. It also lays the groundwork for future revisions and cooperation between the countries signed on. (United Nations, 1951)

2.4 Genocide as an international crime

The “Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court”, adopted in 1998, firmly establishes genocide as one of the four most severe crimes recognized under international law. Genocide falls under the Court’s jurisdiction as outlined in Article 5. Article 6 defines explicitly genocide as acts committed with the Genocide refers the “aim of wiping out, whether fully or partially, a national, ethnic, racial, or religious group. These acts may include the targeted killing of

individuals within the group, causing them serious physical or psychological harm, creating living conditions meant to lead to creating conditions to eliminate the group, restricting its ability to reproduce, or transferring its children to another group by force. children and placing them in another group.” Overall, the Rome Statute comprises 128 articles. (International Criminal Court, 2021)

This definition matches the 1948 UN Genocide Convention but is now part of the legal system managed by the International Criminal Court (ICC). The Rome Statute also makes sure that individuals, no matter what official position they hold, can be held criminally responsible for genocide (Articles 25 and 27), and it states that genocide crimes have no time limit for prosecution (Article 29). By including genocide in this way, the Rome Statute shows that the international community takes the crime seriously and puts in place a system to punish those responsible and help prevent it from happening again. (International Criminal Court, 2021)

3. CZECHIA'S POLICY FRAMEWORK ON GENOCIDE

The Czech Republic criminalizes genocide under Section 400 of its Criminal Code (Act No. 40/2009 Coll.), defining it as acts committed with the “intent to wholly or partially eradicate a racial, ethnic, national, religious, class, or other similar group.” This definition aligns with the 1948 Genocide Convention and Article 6 of the Rome Statute, but notably expands protected groups to include social and political categories. Acts considered punishable include causing severe bodily or psychological suffering, imposing living conditions intended to wipe out the group, or blocking its members from reproducing. In the Czech Republic, genocide is punishable by 12 to 20 years in prison or, in severe cases, by an exceptional sentence, including life imprisonment. Czech law also makes it a crime to deny, approve of, or justify genocide, underscoring the country’s stance against genocidal ideologies. (Cooperation and judicial assistance database, n.d.)

3.1 Czechia’s stance on the UN Genocide Convention

The Czech Republic affirms its legal commitment to the 1948 Genocide Convention as a successor state to Czechoslovakia. Czechoslovakia signed the Convention on 28 December 1949 and ratified it on 21 December 1950. After Czechoslovakia split peacefully, the Czech Republic, notified the United Nations on 22 February 1993 of its intention to uphold all international treaties previously adopted by Czechoslovakia, including the Genocide Convention. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2022a)

3.2 Czechia’s stance on the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court

The Czech Republic signed the Rome Statute in 1999. It demonstrated its strong commitment to the International Criminal Court (ICC) by becoming the 110th State Party upon ratification in 2009 (International Criminal Court, n.d.). Since then, Czechia has kept showing strong support for the key principles of the Rome Statute. It defends the ICC’s independence and stands against political pressure on its staff and partners. In its 2024 statement at the UN, it once again committed to working with others to hold perpetrators accountable. (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2024)

Czechia also supports aligning national legislation with the Rome Statute, emphasizing that no circumstances can justify genocide, war crimes, or crimes against humanity. It welcomes legal

provisions that ensure individual accountability, prohibit forced return, remove statutes of limitation, and allow for meaningful victim participation in legal proceedings. The Czech Republic also supports fair trials, closer international cooperation, and a practical, flexible treaty system that ensures accountability and helps stop future atrocity crimes. (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2023)

3.3 Responsibility to protect principle (R2P)

The Czech Republic firmly supports the full implementation of the Responsibility to protect (R2P) principle, as written in the World Summit Outcome Document formed in 2005. This principle affirms that each state bears the duty of each state to shield “its population from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity—and the obligation of the international community to offer support or, if needed, step in collectively when a state cannot or does not fulfill this responsibility”. (United Nations General Assembly, 2005)

As an active member of the Group of Friends of R2P, Czechia prioritizes the early prevention of atrocity crimes. It advocates for investing in preventive mechanisms, supports the appointment of national R2P, and emphasizes that upholding international human rights, humanitarian, and refugee law is essential for putting the Responsibility to Protect (R2P) into practice in a meaningful way. Czechia also strongly condemns attacks on civilians, humanitarian workers, journalists, and protected institutions (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2018).

The Czech Republic focuses more on prevention and international cooperation than military intervention. It stresses the need for inclusive political processes. It recognizes the key role women play in early warning efforts and preventing conflict, as well as the need to strengthen the Human Rights Council’s preventive functions. Czechia also calls for the universal ratification of the Genocide Convention, confirms its support for the International Criminal Court (ICC), and advocates for making R2P a fixed agenda on the UN General Assembly’s agenda. (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2019a)

3.4 Czech Responses to recent genocidal situations

3.4.1 Genocide in Rwanda

In 1994, when the Czech Republic was a non-permanent member of the UN Security Council, it initially viewed the crisis in Rwanda as not very important and had limited reliable information about what was happening. But that changed under Ambassador Karel Kovanda's leadership. Czechia became the first country on the Council to openly call the atrocities genocide and pushed for a faster, stronger international response, standing strongly behind international law and human rights. (Kovanda, 2010)

Despite these efforts, the Council's final statement ultimately avoided using the term "genocide" and instead used cautious language (National Security Archive, 2014). Czechia put more trust in reports from NGOs than in official UN briefings and wasn't afraid to criticize major powers for their inaction. It viewed the crisis as a turning point that challenged the Security Council's credibility and moral responsibility. (Kovanda, 2010)

3.4.2 Rohingya genocide

The Czech Republic has regularly spoken out against the persecution of the Rohingya in Myanmar, especially after violence escalated in 2016, and has supported global efforts to respond to the crisis. In its statements at the United Nations Human Rights Council, Czechia has called on Myanmar to end human rights violations, including those targeting the Rohingya, and to provide full support to international institutions like the Independent Investigative Mechanism for Myanmar. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2022c)

Czechia has also supported the 2018 United Nations General Assembly resolution on the situation in Myanmar, which strongly condemns all human rights abuses in the country. The resolution drew attention to serious abuses that may amount to persecution or apartheid and condemned the military's violent actions, which drove more than 723,000 Rohingya Muslims and other minorities to flee to Bangladesh. It calls for justice and urges Myanmar to allow displaced people to return safely, voluntarily, and with dignity under international supervision. It also pushes for an end to discriminatory policies, the cancel the unfair laws, and the promotion of interfaith dialogue to help protect vulnerable groups like the Rohingya (United Nations General Assembly, 2018)

3.4.3 Yazidi genocide

The genocide targeting the Yazidi community in Iraq began in 2014 with the rise of ISIS. Although the Czech government hasn't officially used the term "genocide," it has recognized the gravity of the crimes and consistently shown support for the victims in its public statements. In 2019, Czech diplomats co-organized awareness initiatives such as screening the documentary *One Yazidi Family vs ISIS* at the United Nations headquarters. During the event, the Czech mission's deputy representative expressed solidarity with Yazidi and Kurdish leaders, highlighting Czechia's broader commitment to human rights and support for communities affected by mass atrocities (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2019 b).

That same year, the Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs, together with a Czech NGO, helped launch the Shingal Medical Centre in Sinjar, a Yazidi area deeply affected by war. The project focused on improving access to healthcare and was later handed over to local authorities, playing a part in the region's recovery after the conflict. (Consulate General of the Czech Republic in Erbil, 2020)

In 2018, the Czech Consulate General in Erbil partnered with a local NGO to launch the Shingal Bakery in Iraqi Kurdistan. The bakery provides discounted bread to the local community, with proceeds used to support displaced victims of the 2014 ISIS attacks in the Sinjar region, including children living in a nearby orphanage. (Consulate General of the Czech Republic in Erbil, 2018)

3.4.4 Tigray genocide

After fighting broke out in Ethiopia in 2020, many began calling it the Tigray genocide. In response, the Czech Republic provided humanitarian and development aid to help those affected by the conflict. It also backed efforts to support reconciliation, keep Ethiopia stable, and protect its territorial integrity, stressing that the African Union should take the lead in this process. (Embassy of the Czech Republic in Addis Ababa, 2020)

As part of its initial response, the Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs provided 10 million Czech crowns in emergency aid to support refugees in Sudan and Ethiopia affected by the Tigray conflict. Czechia also sent a humanitarian protection expert to the region to help address the crisis on the ground. It supported a separate project, also funded with 10 million crowns aimed

to protect women and girls who have been displaced within national borders. (Embassy of the Czech Republic in Addis Ababa, 2020)

At the multilateral level, the Czech Republic demonstrated its commitment by voting behavior at the United Nations. In 2021, the UN Human Rights Council had a special conference (S-33/1) on the situation in Ethiopia. The resolution condemned all human rights violations and abuses in Tigray and was adopted with Czechia voting in favor. (Universal Rights Group, 2021)

3.4.5 Case between Ukraine and Russia

The Czech Republic has strongly backed the legal proceedings Ukraine brought against Russia before the International Court of Justice, where Ukraine claims Russia is misusing the Genocide Convention. In 2022, Czechia joined the case under Article 63 of the ICJ Statute, pointing out that how the Genocide Convention is interpreted matters to every country—because preventing genocide is something the world must do together. Its main goal was to protect the meaning of the Convention and push back against using it as an excuse for illegal military action. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2022a)

That same year, Czech Prime Minister Petr Fiala publicly invoked historical memory by drawing a direct comparison between the 1995 genocide in Srebrenica and Russia's violent conduct in Ukraine. "In July 1995, genocide in Srebrenica occurred. This event is considered one of the biggest war crimes in Europe since World War II. However it turns out that even today, Europe is not safe," he stated, referring to the suffering of Ukrainian civilians under Russia's unprovoked aggression. (Anadolu Agency, 2022) He emphasized that civilians are once again facing horrific violence, underscoring the need to prioritize European security, especially during the Czech EU Presidency. (Ozturk, 2022)

While the Czech Republic has not officially labeled Russia's actions in Ukraine as "genocide," it remains a firm supporter of Ukraine's legal pursuit at the ICJ. It consistently defends the integrity of the Genocide Convention. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2022 a)

4. EUROPEAN UNION'S POLICY FRAMEWORK ON GENOCIDE

The European Union is firmly committed to prevent and respond to genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity. Within the Justice and Home Affairs framework, the EU supports member states in investigating and prosecuting these serious crimes, aiming to ensure that no part of the Union becomes a safe haven for perpetrators (Eurojust, 2014).

To help make this happen, the Council of the EU established the Genocide Network in 2002. This initiative brings together prosecutors and investigators from across the EU to share information, coordinate their efforts, and strengthen cooperation of judges. Just a year later, the EU decided to expand cross-border collaboration between police and prosecution services. Since 2011, the Network has had steady support from a dedicated team at Eurojust's office in The Hague, which has made it better equipped to deal with serious crimes like genocide and war crimes. (Eurojust, 2014)

But the EU's work doesn't stop at its own borders. Its approach to preventing genocide is deeply tied to defending human rights and working closely with international partners. The EU works closely with global and regional actors, including the United Nations, Council of Europe, African Union, and Inter-American Human Rights System, to promote international legal standards. It regularly backs the work of the International Criminal Court (ICC) and emphasizes the need to follow through on recommendations about "torture and crimes against humanity." (European Union, 2021).

A big part of this approach is the EU's strong backing of the Responsibility to Protect (R2P) principle. For the EU, R2P isn't just an idea, it's a tool for stopping atrocities before they happen. It expects countries to protect their people and crack down on hate speech and incitement early on. That's why the EU puts money into early warning systems, pushes for better data, and works with governments and civil society to deal with potential threats. It also encourages the UN Security Council to act quickly when civilians are in danger and supports international courts in bringing perpetrators to justice. (European Union, 2023)

5. GENOCIDE AGAINST BOSNIAKS IN SREBRENICA, JULY 1995

5.1 Context of the Bosnian war (1992–1995)

Yugoslavia, a multi-ethnic federation formed after World War I, began to fall apart in the early 1990s. After the Cold War ended, the country was hit by a severe economic crisis, rising nationalism, and the loss of strong central leadership after the death of Josip Broz Tito. These growing tensions eventually led Slovenia and Croatia to declare independence, sparking short but fierce fighting with the Serb-led Yugoslav People's Army. (Bjarnason, 2001)

The situation escalated dramatically in Bosnia and Herzegovina, where Bosniaks (Muslims), Serbs (Orthodox Christians), and Croats (Catholics) had long coexisted. Serbia and Croatia both pursued territorial ambitions in Bosnia, while nationalist propaganda, historical memories, and the collapse of communism inflamed rising ethnic tensions. Despite international recognition of Bosnia's independence in 1992, war quickly broke out as the country's ethnic groups fought for land and political control. The result was widespread violence, ethnic cleansing, and the eventual separation of Bosnia. (Bjarnason, 2001)

The war in Bosnia and Herzegovina (1992–1995) unfolded in two phases. It began with fighting between Bosnian Serb forces, supported by the Yugoslav People's Army, and a fragile Bosniak-Croat alliance. In early 1992, Bosnian Serb leaders declared the establishment of Republika Srpska, to unite Serb-populated areas under Serbian control. This move laid the foundation for a campaign of territorial expansion and ethnic cleansing, including atrocities such as the siege of Sarajevo. (personal visit to the Siege of Sarajevo Museum, April 2025)

From late 1992 to early 1994, internal conflict erupted between former allies - the Bosniaks and Croats, resulting in further violence and territorial fragmentation. By 1993, the conflict had evolved into an entirely ethnic war, with three main factions, Bosniaks, Croats, and Serbs, each commanding separate military forces and pursuing their own political goals. (United Nations IRMCT, 2024) Although it wasn't the primary cause of the conflict, religion helped define group identities and was often used to justify violence (Morus, 2010). Groups actively used religious symbols and stories to rally support and intensify divisions. In 1995, the final year of the war, Croatia launched major military offensives, violence flared again, and NATO intervened. These events paved the way for the Dayton Peace Agreement, which ended the war

and established Bosnia as a state of two self-governing entities. (personal visit to the Siege of Sarajevo Museum, April 2025)

5.2 Siege and occupation of Srebrenica

Srebrenica, once a small town with a mixed population, turned into a haven for more than 55,000 people as Muslim civilians fled the violence spreading across eastern Bosnia. Although Bosnian Serb forces captured the town in 1992, Bosnian government forces soon retook it. (Human Rights Watch, 1995)

As the humanitarian crisis deepened, in April 1993, the United Nations Security Council designated Srebrenica as a “safe area”, to protect civilians from further attacks (personal visit to the Memorial Center Srebrenica – Potočari, April 2025). A ceasefire agreement followed, including provisions for demilitarization, the deployment of UNPROFOR peacekeepers, and establishing a humanitarian corridor to Tuzla for evacuating the sick and wounded. UNPROFOR set up a small post in Srebrenica and a larger base near Potočari to monitor the ceasefire and oversee the disarmament process. (United Nations, 1999)

Figure 1: Srebrenica - UN "safe area"



Source: Memorial center Srebrenica – Potočari, own photography

Despite its designation as a safe area, Srebrenica remained under siege for more than three years, with UN aid frequently blocked. The Dutch UN battalion (Dutchbat), led by Commander Thom Karremans and stationed in Potočari, faced severe limitations in resources

and mandate. These constraints made it impossible to defend the enclave from continued Serb offensives. (Human Rights Watch, 1995)

According to Human Rights Watch (1995), between April and May 1992, Bosnian Serb forces, supported by the Yugoslav Army and Serbian paramilitaries, launched a coordinated campaign to remove non-Serb populations from Republika Srpska. Through mass murder, rape, torture, and the destruction of homes and cultural sites, they carried out a systematic ethnic cleansing operation, primarily targeting Bosnian Muslims. The fall of towns like Srebrenica and Čepa marked the elimination of non-Serb populations from eastern Bosnia.

5.3 Genocide in July 1995

5.3.1 Directive 7 and Krivaja 95

In March 1995, Radovan Karadžić, serving as both President and supreme military authority of the self-proclaimed Republika Srpska, issued “Directive 7,” ordering the removal of the Muslim population from the Srebrenica and Žepa enclaves. The directive tasked the Army of Republika Srpska (VRS) with carrying out military operations to create conditions of total insecurity, making survival impossible for Bosniak civilians. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

In July 1995, the Bosnian Serb forces carried out Directive 7 through a military operation known as “Krivaja 95.” This campaign resulted in the execution or disappearance of approximately 8,000 Bosniak men and boys, while around 30,000 women, children, and Bosnian Serb forces forcibly expelled elderly individuals from the Srebrenica enclave. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

5.3.2 Fall of Srebrenica

Bosnian Serb forces besieged Srebrenica and cut it off from supplies to starve the population. In July 1995, facing a weakening military position, Bosnian Serb leaders launched a final assault. Bosnian Serb forces targeted and killed Bosniak men and boys in an organized manner, while they violently displaced women and children from the area. Scholars regard the massacre, led by General Ratko Mladić, as the culmination of a broader campaign of genocide in eastern Bosnia. (Hoare, 2021)

5.3.3 The march of death

On July 11th 1995, thousands of men and boys, along with a few women, formed a column in an attempt to escape through Serb-controlled territory toward Tuzla. Armed with a few guns the people faced constant attacks. Of the estimated 12,000–15,000 people who set out, only about 5,000 reached Tuzla by July 16th. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

5.3.4 Mass executions and mass graves

Thousands of men and boys were captured and executed without trial, either on the spot or after transportation to detention sites. The first major mass execution occurred at the Kravica warehouse, where about 1,000 prisoners were shot, with only one survivor. Other victims were detained at Bratunac's football stadium before being executed. Their remains were eventually placed in mass graves (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

The Institute for the Missing Persons in Bosnia and Herzegovina has recorded 8,372 persons whose fate or death is related to the events in Srebrenica in July 1995 (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025).

Figure 2: Cemetery of the Srebrenica genocide



Source: own photography

5.3.5 Responsibility and failure of international protection

The UN report noted that Dutchbat, the Dutch UN battalion stationed in Srebrenica, never fired directly at Serb units and suggested that engagement might have changed the outcome. The report criticized Dutchbat's light armament, poor positioning, and failure to fully report the situation after the town's fall, suggesting that better information could have triggered a stronger international response, possibly saving lives. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

5.3.6 Memorialization

Authorities transformed the former Dutchbat base at Potočari into a memorial site, which now includes a Memorial Room and the “Black Room,” known as the Memorial Center Srebrenica – Potočari. The former Dutchbat base now displays personal items recovered from mass graves. It includes a cemetery opened in 2003, where annual commemorations are held, standing as a permanent reminder of the genocide and the international community's failure to prevent it. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

5.4 Dayton peace agreement

The Dayton Agreement, officially called the General Framework Agreement for Peace, was a legal document that officially ended the conflict in Bosnia and Herzegovina. It was initialed in Dayton, Ohio, and officially signed in Paris, on December 14th, 1995. The Dayton Agreement includes 11 annexes. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

It reaffirmed Bosnia and Herzegovina's sovereignty, independence, and territorial integrity. It divided the country into the Federation of Bosnia and Herzegovina and the Republika Srpska as its two entities (personal visit to the Siege of Sarajevo Museum, April 2025).

According to the Head of Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari (email communication, April 2025), the post-conflict division of Bosnia and Herzegovina is an issue, and the country still suffers from a security and political situation. The Srebrenica Memorial Center, although a state institution, is located within the Republika Srpska entity, often making it a target of criticism and political pressure from its authorities.

Figure 3: Division of Bosnia and Herzegovina after the war



Source: Institut Jacques Delors (2024)

5.5 Judgement and tribunal for Yugoslavia

5.5.1 Establishment and mission of the ICTY

In May 1993, the United Nations set up the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia (ICTY) after reports of mass killings, torture, sexual violence, and forced displacement in the wars in Croatia and Bosnia and Herzegovina. These crimes pushed the UN Security Council to act under Chapter VII of the UN Charter. It was the first tribunal since Nuremberg and Tokyo, created to hold those most responsible for the worst crimes accountable and to help bring justice and lasting peace to the region. (International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia, n.d.)

Based in The Hague, Netherlands, the ICTY indicted over 160 individuals, including senior political, military, and police leaders, former presidents, prime ministers, and top-ranking officers. These indictments addressed crimes committed between 1991 and 2001 across the territories of Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Serbia, Kosovo, and North Macedonia (International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia, n.d.).

5.5.2 Prosecutions related to Srebrenica

The Srebrenica massacre of July 1995 was later legally recognized as genocide by both the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia (ICTY) and the International Court

of Justice (ICJ) (personal visit to the Memorial Center Srebrenica–Potočari, April 2025). Initial reports of mass executions emerged in a 1995 document by the UN Special Rapporteur, followed by further updates to the Security Council. However, ICTY investigators were granted access to key sites in early 1996. Forensic evidence and survivor testimonies later confirmed the existence of mass graves and systematic executions. (Čekić, 2007)

Among the most well-known convictions were those of Radovan Karadžić, the political head of the Bosnian Serbs, and Ratko Mladić, the army's top commander. Both received life sentences for genocide and other serious crimes. In 2004, Radislav Krstić, a high-ranking military officer, became the first individual the ICTY found guilty of genocide and was given a 35-year prison sentence. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

Despite these significant rulings, many lower-level perpetrators remain unpunished, and some continue to hold political influence in Republika Srpska. (personal visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center–Potočari, April 2025)

6. THE CZECH REPUBLIC'S FOREIGN POLICY ON THE SREBRENICA GENOCIDE (1995–2025)

6.1 Official Czech foreign policy towards Bosnia and Herzegovina

Bosnia and Herzegovina has consistently been one of the Czech Republic's key foreign policy priorities. The 2010–2017 Development Cooperation Strategy placed it in the highest category of priority countries. This step highlighted the region's strategic value and signaled a clear intention to build long-term, organized cooperation focused on development, stability, and closer relations between the two countries. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2018)

Providing balanced support to both major ethnic groups and promoting overall stability in Bosnia and Herzegovina are key priorities in Czechia's development cooperation efforts (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2013).

As noted by the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina (personal communication, April 2025), Czech foreign policy toward Bosnia is influenced by its broader strategic interests, particularly in the Middle East and Ukraine. At the same time, it maintains a firm commitment to promoting stability in the Western Balkans, with continued support for human rights, democratic reforms, historical accountability, and regional peace. In line with these priorities, the Czech Embassy in Sarajevo is preparing a water management project aimed explicitly at the municipality of Srebrenica.

6.1.1 Post-conflict assistance

After the 1992–1995 war, the Czech Republic first concentrated on sending humanitarian aid and helping rebuild Bosnia and Herzegovina. As time went on, its efforts shifted more toward supporting the country's stability and development, especially as it worked toward joining the European Union. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2018)

Based on the Deputy Ambassador of Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina (personal communication, April 2025), the Czech Republic has shown its long-term commitment to post-war societal reconstruction through cooperation between officials of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Office of the High Representative (OHR) on matters of reconciliation in Bosnia and Herzegovina. The Czech Republic has also backed the House of Good Tones in Srebrenica, a cultural and educational center that provides creative and learning opportunities for children

and young people. The project represents a valuable step toward post-conflict healing and encourages multicultural understanding in the region.

6.1.2 Development cooperation

Between 2010 and 2017, Bosnia and Herzegovina was designated a “priority country” in the Czech Republic’s Development Cooperation Strategy. The bilateral programme focused on key areas such as water and sanitation, environmental protection, energy, healthcare, agriculture, and support for civil society and good governance. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2018)

In the 2018–2023 strategy, Czech development cooperation adopted broader priorities, including gender equality, climate change mitigation, and poverty reduction, applied across all focus areas. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2018)

As of 2025, Czech development efforts in Bosnia and Herzegovina concentrate on government and civil society, environmental protection, water supply, energy, agriculture, and healthcare. These activities are guided by crosscutting principles such as good governance, respect for human rights, and commitment to protecting the environment, especially in relation to climate change (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2025 b).

A researcher at the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law, University of Sarajevo (email communication, April 2025) said: “It is certainly best for Czech Republic to work on developing and supporting programs and projects that concern the development of a culture of remembrance of events that befell societies that were affected by conflict, or post-conflict societies.”

6.1.3 Support for EU and NATO integration

A stable and cooperative neighborhood is vital for the Czech Republic, the European Union, and overall European security. To support Bosnia and Herzegovina’s democratic development, economic governance, and progress toward EU integration, the Czech Republic assists in reforming public institutions, aligning state agencies with EU standards, and strengthening key sectors such as agriculture and healthcare. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2018)

Bosnia and Herzegovina maintains strong relations with the Czech Republic and values its experience in democratic transition and EU accession. In 2012, Czechia partnered with other international donors to enhance the impact of the development program in the country (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2013). As a committed advocate for Bosnia's EU membership, the Czech Republic is part of the group of seven "friends of the Western Balkans" and has actively supported the opening of accession negotiations. (Hina, 2024)

According to the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina (personal communication, April 2025), the Czech Republic actively supports Bosnia and Herzegovina's European integration, particularly through its involvement in the Group of Friends of the Western Balkans. He stressed that facing the past, holding war criminals accountable, and building better relations with neighboring countries are all key for Bosnia and Herzegovina's path toward EU membership. At the same time, he pointed out that EU member states remain split on the issue and called for the Czech Republic to take a more active role and clearly state its position within the EU context.

Czechia also supports NATO enlargement and the integration of aspirant countries, including Bosnia and Herzegovina, viewing the Alliance's expansion as a means to strengthen collective defense, regional stability, and its capacity to respond to security challenges. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2025a)

6.2 Evolution of Czech Diplomatic Discourse on Srebrenica

6.2.1 Year 1995

On November 9th, 1995, during its 3612th meeting, the UN Security Council unanimously adopted Resolution 1019, which responded to serious breaches of international humanitarian law in Bosnia and Herzegovina, including those committed in Srebrenica and Žepa. The resolution called for immediate access for international agencies to persons detained or reported missing in these areas. (United Nations Security Council, 1995b) During the session, the Czech Republic, represented by diplomat Karel Kovanda, co-sponsored the resolution and delivered a powerful statement on the Srebrenica genocide. Kovanda called the events a "failure of imagination" and explained that while people expected the massacre, no one had imagined the extent of the atrocities. He compared it to how the international community failed

to stop the genocide in Rwanda, stressing how crucial it is to spot warning signs early and take decisive action. (United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2015)

The Czech Republic further demonstrated its commitment to peace in the region by contributing a substantial unit to the NATO-led Implementation Force, expressing confidence in the peace process. Czech representatives welcomed the signing of the Peace Agreement by the leaders of Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia, and supported the suspension of economic sanctions against the latter. (United Nations Security Council, 1995a).

In 1995, under the Presidency of Václav Havel, Czechia visibly supported Bosnia's case. Havel launched a month-long campaign in solidarity with Bosnia, and he visited Sarajevo in late 1995, symbolizing Czech support for the victims of the war. (History Museum of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 2022)

6.2.2 Late 1990s

In the late 1990s, the Czech Republic consistently supported international efforts to bring justice for the crimes committed in Srebrenica. Czechia strongly supported the work of the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia (ICTY) and actively worked with its investigations, in line with UN standards. Czech officials viewed the Tribunal as an important way to hold perpetrators accountable, combat impunity, and seek justice for crimes such as ethnic cleansing in Bosnia and Herzegovina. At the same time, they expressed concern about those who blocked the Tribunal's efforts by hiding evidence or denying access to important sites. (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2002)

The Czech Republic also demonstrated its involvement in international justice through its legal contributions. A good example is Ivana Janů, a respected Czech judge who served as an ad litem judge at the ICTY. Her involvement in trials connected to the Srebrenica genocide reflected Czechia's recognition of the seriousness of these crimes and its strong backing for international justice. (International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia, 2017)

In 1999, the Czech Republic supported NATO's military intervention in the Balkans, partly in response to the the international community's inability to prevent the genocide in Bosnia. President Václav Havel openly backed the air strikes, saying they were driven by humanitarian values and the need to defend human rights, not by politics or strategic gains. (Morteska, 2023)

6.2.3 Year 2005

A decade after the Srebrenica genocide marked a turning point in the Czech Republic's formal acknowledgment of the atrocity, the Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a statement explicitly recognizing the massacre as genocide, calling it "undoubtedly the worst single atrocity in Europe since the end of World War II." (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

For years, the full extent of the Srebrenica massacre was questioned or denied by some, and its classification as genocide was subject to debate. However, with the accumulation of overwhelming evidence and clear rulings by international courts, the Czech Republic publicly recognized that the crimes committed in Srebrenica constituted genocide. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

In its anniversary statement, the Czech Republic also called on political leaders in Bosnia and Herzegovina and across the region to reject the nationalist ideologies of the 1990s that disregarded human rights and enabled crimes against civilians. It warned against glorifying these past actions as heroic or patriotic. It emphasized that true reconciliation requires Serbs, Croats, and Bosniaks to confront the crimes committed in their names and accept responsibility. Only through this process, the Czech government stated, could the region prevent the repetition of such tragedies. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

Srebrenica has come to represent the deep suffering of the Bosnian War and the international community's failure to prevent genocide. The Czech Republic supported Bosnia and Herzegovina in dealing with the war's long-term impact and in promoting justice, reconciliation, and lasting stability. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

6.2.4 Early 2010s

In the early 2010s, the Czech Republic got involved in efforts to support reconciliation in the Western Balkans. A key moment came in March 2010, when Serbia's parliament passed a resolution acknowledging the Srebrenica massacre and expressing regret. Although the resolution did not explicitly use the term "genocide," it condemned "the killing of 8,000 Muslims" and offered an official apology. As an EU member, the Czech Republic welcomed this step as a move toward regional healing. Czech diplomat Štefan Füle, then serving as EU Commissioner for Enlargement, and EU High Representative Catherine Ashton, described the

resolution as “a significant step” essential for Serbia’s reckoning with its past. (Tvoříme Evropu, 2010)

At the time, Czech foreign policy closely aligned with the EU’s position, supporting Serbia’s path to EU membership, but only on the condition that it fully cooperated in prosecuting war crimes and advancing reconciliation. This also meant expecting that key runaways would be brought to justice, such as Ratko Mladić, would face justice. Authorities eventually captured Mladić in 2011. The Czech Republic emphasized that acknowledging the Srebrenica genocide was not about assigning collective guilt to the Serbian people, but about recognizing historical responsibility as the foundation for sustainable peace. (Pavlíček, 2024)

Czech analysts and diplomats were also aware of the region's denial and selective memory challenges. A Czech expert observed that many in Serbia still reject the idea of collective guilt, highlighting how some leaders remain unwilling to fully accept what took place in Srebrenica. (Pavlíček, 2024)

6.2.5 Year 2015

Global commemorations and renewed political focus marked the twentieth anniversary of the Srebrenica genocide in 2015. In Czechia, officials held ceremonies to honor the victims and show support for Bosnia and Herzegovina. Czech leaders backed the European Parliament’s strong position on the massacre and its push to remember what happened and demand justice. That July, the European Parliament passed a resolution, backed by Czech representatives, honoring all victims of the Srebrenica genocide. The resolution strongly condemned the genocide and rejected any form of denial, relativization, or misinterpretation. Czech Members of the European Parliament voted in favor, aligning themselves with the broader EU consensus and sending a clear message of solidarity with Bosnia and Herzegovina during the painful anniversary. (European Parliament, 2017)

Across the Czech political spectrum, lawmakers participated in commemorative activities, including moments of silence and formal recognition of the genocide. Many parliamentarians and civil society voices emphasized that fully confronting the crime of Srebrenica was necessary for future peace and reconciliation in the region. On this anniversary, Czechia paid tribute to the victims, clearly rejected any denial of the genocide, and restated its resolve to help prevent such crimes from ever happening again. (European Parliament, 2017)

Foreign Minister at the time, Lubomír Zaorálek, underscored the importance of justice and remembrance, stating that crimes like Srebrenica must never happen again. Both chambers of the Czech Parliament paid tribute to the victims, while Speaker Jan Hamáček took part in international and domestic commemorations. He attended the official memorial ceremony in Potočari, Bosnia, and also spoke at a parallel event in Prague, honoring the over 8,000 Bosniak men and boys murdered in 1995. (Institute of International Relations, 2015)

Notably, the then-Czech President Miloš Zeman maintained a low profile during the anniversary. Unlike many other European leaders, Zeman did not attend the official ceremony in Potočari nor issue a formal statement to mark the occasion. Instead, Speaker Jan Hamáček led the Czech delegation and represented the country. Zeman's absence and silence drew domestic criticism, especially when contrasted with the public condemnations and visible gestures of solidarity expressed by other EU heads of state. (Institute of International Relations, 2015)

Attention also turned to the international stage, where a United Nations Security Council resolution sought to officially recognize the Srebrenica massacre as genocide. Although the resolution had backing from the United States, France, and several other countries, Russia vetoed it in July 2015. In echoing the EU's stance, Czech officials voiced disappointment over the veto, which many saw as an attempt to politicize a historical tragedy. (The Guardian, 2015; European Parliament, 2017)

6.2.6 Late 2010s

In the late 2010s, Czech political and public figures openly rejected genocide denial. No prominent public figures questioned the reality of the Srebrenica genocide, and mainstream political leaders and media consistently upheld its recognition. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2019)

Czech officials increasingly used the memory of Srebrenica as a warning against rising nationalism and historical amnesia. In July 2019, then Foreign Minister at that time - Tomáš Petříček, cautioned that growing nationalism in the Balkans risked following "the same path that led to Srebrenica." His remarks reflected a broader political consensus that remembrance must safeguard against repeating past atrocities. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2019)

During the second half of the 2010s, the Czech Republic remained committed to commemorating the genocide and supporting justice. As the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia (ICTY) concluded its work, Czech media and commentators welcomed the 2017 life sentence handed down to General Ratko Mladić for genocide and other crimes. (Česká televize, 2021)

6.2.7 Year 2020

In 2020, the Czech Republic took a clearer stand on Srebrenica, both at home and abroad. Marking 25 years since the genocide, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs joined in remembrance efforts, even with the challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic. Public events were scaled down, but the Czech government released an official video message and joined an online commemoration organized by the Bosnian Embassy in Prague. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2020) In his video, the then-Foreign Minister Tomáš Petříček highlighted the importance of memory, justice, and historical responsibility. He warned that Europe remains vulnerable to mass violence and emphasized that the Srebrenica genocide must never be forgotten or justified. Referring to it as a deep trauma for Bosnia and Herzegovina, he urged honest reconciliation and drew a parallel to Czech-German postwar healing as a model for the Balkans. He also expressed hope for Bosnia and Herzegovina's future as a democratic member of the European Union. (Fokus.ba, 2020)

To further underscore this message, the Czech Ambassador at that time to Bosnia and Herzegovina, Jakub Skalník, attended a smaller memorial ceremony in Potočari, representing the Czech Republic in person. His presence, along with official messages from Prague, affirmed that the Czech Republic views Srebrenica as a European tragedy—one that must be remembered with respect and understood as a powerful reminder of the importance of tolerance, peace, and the dangers of extremist behaviour. (Embassy of the Czech Republic in Sarajevo, 2020)

6.2.8 Year 2024

In 2024, the Czech Republic reaffirmed its strong commitment to commemorating the Srebrenica genocide and strengthening ties with Bosnia and Herzegovina. A major symbolic gesture came when Markéta Pekarová Adamová, head of the Czech Chamber of Deputies, visited the Srebrenica-Potočari Memorial Center to pay tribute to the victims of the 1995 genocide. (N1Sarajevo, 2024)

Based on the Head of Memorial Center in Srebrenica – Potočari (email communication, April 2025), Pekarová Adamová and her delegation held a meeting with Amra Begić, Assistant Director of the Srebrenica Memorial Center, along with representatives of associations of genocide victims' families. The talks focused on the need to remember the genocide and defend the truth about what happened. After the meeting, the Czech delegation went to the memorial cemetery as a sign of respect and support for the victims and their families. The visit showed that Czechia remains committed to truth, justice, and human rights, standing alongside the international community.

Later that year, the Czech Parliament officially took part in the 29th anniversary of the Srebrenica genocide. As Czech Ambassador Mlinarević noted at the time, the gesture reflected Czechia's lasting solidarity with Bosnia. "This is truly significant and important for us. We are grateful to the friendly members of parliament who will co-organize the commemoration together with our embassy," she stated. (Preporod.info, 2024)

Diplomatic cooperation between the two countries also deepened in 2024. During a meeting in Sarajevo, Czech Foreign Minister Jan Lipavský and Bosnian Foreign Minister Elmedin Konaković signed an agreement allowing the Czech Diplomatic Academy to train Bosnian diplomats as a closer step towards bilateral engagement. (Hina, 2024)

In a further show of commitment, newly appointed Czech Ambassador Ana K. Lolić Šindelková made her first official visit to the Srebrenica Memorial Center. She met with Deputy Director Amra Begić and Museum Head Azir Osmanović, who briefed her on the Center's activities and preparations for the upcoming 30th anniversary of the genocide. They also discussed the persistent problem of genocide denial, which continues to cause a challenge nearly three decades later. The ambassador toured the exhibitions and honored the victims by laying flowers and praying at the cemetery. (Memorijalni centar Srebrenica, 2024)

According to the Head of Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari (email communication, April 2025), "it is encouraging that there is currently a wonderful ambassador representing the Czech Republic in Bosnia and Herzegovina. I don't doubt that previous ambassadors were good as well. This ambassador has visited the Srebrenica Memorial Center three times in the past year. We have discussed various topics and potential cooperation. I hope we will develop concrete projects in the future aimed at educating younger generations in the Czech Republic about the genocide in Srebrenica."

6.2.8.1 UN General Assembly resolution

In May 2024, the UN General Assembly passed a historic resolution declaring July 11th as the “International Day of Reflection and Remembrance for the 1995 Srebrenica Genocide.” The resolution not only designated this official day of remembrance but also firmly condemned any denial of the Srebrenica genocide. It urged all member states to preserve historical truth through education and to combat denial and distortion of genocide actively. (United Nations General Assembly, 2024)

The resolution was adopted with 84 votes in favor, 19 against, and 68 members choosing to abstain. The Czech Republic was among the 84 countries that supported the resolution, clearly affirming its stance on recognizing and remembering the genocide (United Nations General Assembly, 2024).

“Such forms of participation and participation of the Czech Republic are important for preserving the collective culture of memory and spreading a clear message that such evil will never happen again to anyone in the world. The position of the Czech Republic on these issues and its approval of the Srebrenica resolution by the UN General Assembly, as well as the organization of commemorations every July 11th of the year, are worthy of praise and respect.” (researcher at the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law, University of Sarajevo, email communication, April 2025).

Figure 4: United Nations General Assembly resolution - voting



Source: United Nations General Assembly (2024)

According to the Czech Embassy in Sarajevo, the resolution emphasizes the importance of protecting facts through education to prevent history from repeating. It also speaks out against praising convicted war criminals and stresses the need to keep searching for the remaining victims of Srebrenica. (Dnevni Avaz, 2024)

According to the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina (personal communication, April 2025), Srebrenica is a symbol that must “never be repeated, what is forgotten, will be repeated,” marking the importance of Czechia’s voting in favor of the United Nations General Assembly resolution.

“This confirms that the Czech government has chosen the side of truth and justice. The visit of your country’s diplomats to the Srebrenica Memorial Center is further evidence that you acknowledge the genocide, which has been internationally recognized by court rulings” (Head of Memorial Center Srebrenica – Potočari, email communication, April 2025).

6.2.9 Year 2025

In January 2025, President Petr Pavel traveled to Bosnia and Herzegovina, where he held meetings with members of the country’s Presidency for official discussions. During the visit, he stressed the need to move past internal divisions to push forward with the country’s EU integration. He warned that “if these countries remain in a grey zone, it only benefits those who want to stir up instability in Europe,” highlighting how crucial EU and Euro-Atlantic integration is for lasting peace and stability. (N1 Sarajevo, 2025)

7. INFLUENCING FACTORS: HISTORICAL, POLITICAL, AND INTERNATIONAL CONTEXT

7.1 Historical factors

A key influence is the tradition of Czech humanism, particularly the ideas of Tomáš Garrigue Masaryk, along with the democratic aspirations expressed during the Prague Spring and later through Charter 77. These legacies have reinforced a long-standing belief in human rights as essential to a dignified life. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2015)

Czech foreign policy has also been shaped by the country's own experiences with injustice, particularly the years of repression under Soviet-backed communism. These chapters of history have contributed to a strong moral awareness in how Czechia engages with the world. Czech leaders often invoked these past experiences when addressing mass atrocities such as the Srebrenica genocide. For example, in its 2005 statement marking the 10th anniversary of the genocide, the Czech Foreign Ministry described Srebrenica as “undoubtedly the worst single atrocity in Europe since the end of World War II,” placing it in direct continuity with the horrors of the Holocaust. Czech officials have often compared the remembrance of the Holocaust with that of Srebrenica, stressing how vital it is to remember and educate so that such tragedies are never repeated. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005; Cadier, 2016)

The peaceful split of Czechoslovakia in 1993 was a key moment in shaping Czech foreign policy. As a newly independent, post-communist country, Czechia set out to redefine itself as a democratic, Western-leaning state grounded in international law and a strong commitment to human rights. (Drulák, 2008) This early shift gave Czechia the chance to take clear stands on issues like genocide and humanitarian intervention, even before its foreign policy system was entirely in place (European Parliament, 2009)

7.2 Political factors

7.2.1 Government

While the Czech Republic's early post-communist governments showed uncertainty in responding to the Srebrenica genocide, by the 2000s, a clear domestic political consensus had emerged, marked by unequivocal condemnation of the atrocity and increasing support for its

commemoration. In the years immediately following the genocide in 1995, there were no major official statements, public speeches, or formal commemorative actions from Czech political leaders. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

This began to shift in the early 2000s, with a significant turning point in 2005 when the Ministry of Foreign Affairs officially recognized the seriousness of the crime, calling it “undoubtedly the worst single atrocity in Europe since the end of World War II.” That statement signaled the start of a more engaged and morally driven approach to addressing the legacy of Srebrenica. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

Since then, the Czech government has steadily increased its support for remembrance and justice, especially during major anniversaries of the genocide. The 10th, 15th, 20th, and 25th anniversaries were all marked by official gestures such as statements, commemorative events, and visits from Czech foreign ministers, members of parliament, and ambassadors to the Srebrenica-Potočari Memorial Center. (European Parliament, 2017)

7.2.2 Presidency

The first president of the independent Czech Republic (1993–2003), Václav Havel, played a key role in shaping the country’s post-communist foreign policy by strongly emphasizing human rights. Following the dissolution of Czechoslovakia, Havel emerged as an early advocate for Bosnia and Herzegovina during the 1990s conflict. (Drulák, 2008) In 1995, as reports of genocide in Srebrenica surfaced, Havel launched a month-long public campaign in support of Bosnia. His principled stance and moral leadership set a high standard for the Czech Republic’s international engagement. (History Museum of Bosnia and Herzegovina, 2022)

In contrast, later political leaders did not always uphold the same public commitment to Bosnia and Srebrenica. President Miloš Zeman (2013–2023) kept a low profile during important remembrance events. He did not issue an important public statement to mark the Srebrenica anniversary, nor did he attend the official ceremonies - an absence noted and criticized by observers (Institute of International Relations, 2015). Although Zeman had initially supported NATO operations during the Kosovo conflict as prime minister in 1999, his views evolved. In 2021, he publicly apologized for the NATO bombing of Yugoslavia, describing Czech participation under his leadership as a "lack of courage" and asking for forgiveness. (Radio Free Europe, 2021)

Under President Petr Pavel, the Czech foreign policy returned to a more proactive, pro-European, and human-rights-based approach. A former NATO general, Pavel brought strong transatlantic credentials to the presidency (Office of the President of the Czech Republic, n.d.). Under his leadership, Czechia backed the 2024 UN General Assembly resolution declaring July 11th as the “International Day of Reflection and Commemoration of the 1995 Genocide in Srebrenica” (United Nations General Assembly, 2024). Reflecting on his earlier military career, Pavel noted that NATO’s intervention in the Balkans was necessary "to prevent another Srebrenica" (Fiala, 2020).

In the late 1990s, Czech politicians disagreed on the issue. While President Havel firmly backed humanitarian intervention, others, like Foreign Minister Jan Kavan and former Prime Minister Václav Klaus, were more cautious or openly critical of NATO’s actions. (Radio Free Europe, 1999)

7.3 International factors

The broader international environment, mainly the role of the United Nations, NATO, and the European Union, formulated Czechia’s response and policies to Srebrenica and its commitment to the West. Based on the Head of Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari (email communication, April 2025), “the support of the international community and state engagement in Bosnia and Herzegovina is key. This shows that genocide deniers are simply waiting for the right moment to rewrite history and impose their own narrative.”

7.3.1 UN

The United Nations played a central role from the outset in influencing how the Czech Republic responded to the Srebrenica genocide. In November 1995, only a few months after the atrocity, the UN Security Council unanimously passed Resolution 1019, which condemned the 'serious violations of international humanitarian law' in Bosnia and called for access to those still missing from Srebrenica. (United Nations Security Council, 1995 c) The Czech Republic co-sponsored the resolution and expressed deep shock at the scale of the atrocities. Czech UN Ambassador Karel Kovanda described the massacre as a “failure of imagination,” acknowledging that the international community had not anticipated genocide of such magnitude. (United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2015)

This early engagement helped solidify the Czech Republic's commitment to justice and accountability. The Czech government firmly backed the efforts of the International Criminal Tribunal for the Former Yugoslavia (ICTY), the UN-established court tasked with prosecuting war crimes in the former Yugoslavia, including the Srebrenica genocide. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2017)

The United Nations continued to play a key role in guiding Czech foreign policy in following years. In July 2015, when Russia blocked a UN Security Council resolution aimed at formally recognizing the Srebrenica massacre as genocide, Czech officials joined the European Union consensus in expressing deep regret. They criticized the politicization of historical truth and reaffirmed their support for international recognition of the genocide. (The Guardian, 2015)

Czech diplomacy has also consistently backed broader UN-led initiatives on genocide prevention, implementing the Responsibility to Protect (R2P) doctrine, which stresses the global obligation to step in and prevent mass atrocities (Permanent Mission of the Czech Republic to the United Nations, 2019a).

In 2024, Czechia once again stood by the principles of the United Nations by joining 83 other countries in supporting a historic UN General Assembly resolution that declared July 11th the "International Day of Reflection and Remembrance for the 1995 Srebrenica Genocide." By voting in favor, Czechia sent a clear message about its dedication to honoring the truth, remembering the victims, and working to prevent future genocides. (United Nations General Assembly, 2024)

7.3.2 NATO

In the late 1990s, as the Czech Republic prepared to join NATO, the lessons of Srebrenica had a clear impact on how its leaders thought about security and foreign policy. In 1996, following the Dayton Peace Agreement, Czechia sent 800 troops to Bosnia as part of NATO's peacekeeping force, IFOR, showing it was willing to step in and help bring stability to the region. This early move into peacekeeping reflected Czechia's broader commitment to international security and helping countries recover after conflict. (Radio Free Europe, 1996)

According to Mokretska (2023), this engagement with NATO missions helped raise Czech awareness of the consequences of mass atrocities and called attention to the significance of

working together globally to prevent genocide. It also laid the groundwork for a more active Czech role in humanitarian and military interventions.

The influence of Srebrenica was also evident in Czech responses to NATO's 1999 intervention in Kosovo. The then-President Václav Havel strongly supported the operation, describing it as an "extreme solution" made necessary by the urgent need to prevent further civilian suffering. He placed the responsibility for the crisis squarely on Yugoslav President Slobodan Milošević. He pointed to Srebrenica as a powerful reminder of what can happen when the world stays silent in the face of mass violence. (Mokretska, 2023)

7.3.3 EU

Joining the European Union in 2004 had a major influence on how Czechia dealt with genocide and efforts to prevent mass atrocities. Becoming part of the EU meant adopting its values and policies, particularly those focused on human rights, transitional justice, and holding perpetrators of war crimes accountable. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, n.d.)

The EU made the recognition and prosecution of war crimes a cornerstone of its policy toward the Western Balkans. Czechia showed this through its political discourse and concrete actions, such as the "EU Support to Confidence Building in the Western Balkans" project, which aimed to strengthen regional cooperation and support accountability processes for war crimes. (United Nations Development Programme, n.d.)

A strong example of this alignment appeared in 2005, when the European Parliament passed a resolution marking the tenth anniversary of the Srebrenica genocide. The resolution stressed that full cooperation with the International Criminal Tribunal for the Former Yugoslavia (ICTY) was essential for progressing with EU integration. Czech representatives echoed this message, firmly supporting justice and accountability. (EWB Archives, 2015)

By this time, Czech diplomatic language had evolved to mirror EU norms. To mark the 10th anniversary of the genocide, the Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs explicitly referred to Srebrenica as genocide and described it as "undoubtedly the worst single atrocity in Europe since the end of World War II." (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

As an EU member, the Czech Republic participated in broader European commemorative and reconciliation efforts. In 2010, when Serbia's parliament issued a resolution expressing regret for Srebrenica, Czech officials joined other EU leaders in welcoming the move as "an important step" toward reconciliation in the region. (Reuters, 2010)

Czechia's commitment to the EU's commitment to justice and preventing mass atrocities grew stronger over time, reflected in both political backing and financial support for institutions like the International Criminal Court and participation in EU resolutions commemorating atrocities like Srebrenica. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2024) The Czech Republic has also supported EU conditionality, which requires acknowledgment of past crimes as a condition for Western Balkan countries seeking EU accession (UNDP, n.d.).

The Head of the Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari (email communication, April 2025) emphasized the positive influence of the European Union on the Czech Republic's engagement, noting: "I've also noticed a greater presence of Czech representatives within the EU Delegation and EUFOR in Bosnia and Herzegovina, so there is a lot of room for collaboration."

8. ALIGNMENT VS DIVERGENCE CZECHIA AND EU

8.1 Response to 1995 events

In 1995, during the immediate aftermath of the Srebrenica massacre, the Czech Republic's response was relatively reserved yet diplomatically engaged. Karel Kovanda, serving at the time as the Czechia's permanent representative to the UN spoke before the Security Council about the crisis. He made it clear that Czechia was taking a careful but firm stand, he condemned the mass killings and other violations of international humanitarian law and called on all parties to respect the Security Council's decisions. Kovanda also highlighted the need for complete collaboration with the International Criminal Tribunal for the Former Yugoslavia (ICTY), framing justice as essential to achieving lasting peace in the Balkans. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 1995)

By contrast, most European governments in 1995 delayed acknowledging the crisis and took little direct action. The international community, including many EU member states, was widely criticized for its inaction and lack of coordination. The Netherlands, in particular, faced intense public and institutional scrutiny for its failure to prevent the massacre, despite having Dutch UN peacekeepers stationed in the designated "safe area" of Srebrenica, the inability of Dutch forces to protect civilians became a symbol of the broader failure of European and international actors to respond effectively to mass atrocity. (Karčić, 2015)

8.2 10th anniversary of the Srebrenica massacre

In 2005, marking ten years since the genocide, the Czech Republic officially recognized the massacre as genocide. It issued statements from both the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Head of the state (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005). Gradually, European institutions came to recognize the significance of the tragedy. In 2005, the European Parliament passed a resolution identifying Srebrenica as a symbol of the EU's shortcomings in responding to the conflict and urging its remembrance (Karčić, 2015).

8.3 20th anniversary of the Srebrenica massacre

On the 20th anniversary in 2015, the Speaker of the Chamber of Deputies, Jan Hamáček, personally attended the commemoration ceremony in Srebrenica and delivered a speech at a parallel memorial event in Prague. Similarly, Foreign Minister Lubomír Zaorálek emphasized

the importance of upholding justice and stopping similar atrocities from happening in the future. (Institute of International Relations, 2015)

Twenty years after the Srebrenica genocide, the European Union honored all victims and expressed deep solidarity with their families. It strongly condemned the genocide, rejected any denial or distortion, and urged Bosnia and Herzegovina's leaders to confront the past as a foundation for a better future. The EU emphasized the role of the ICTY, encouraged regional cooperation and European integration as pathways to reconciliation, supported educational initiatives to promote peace, and voiced disappointment over the UN Security Council's inability to pass a commemorative resolution. (European Parliament, 2017)

On the 20th anniversary, a significant symbol of this commitment is the annual statement by Joseph Borell - the EU key Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Strategy, who consistently emphasizes the importance of historical memory and justice in a form of justice for the victims, acknowledgment of historical facts, and rejection of genocide denial (European Union: External Action, 2024).

8.4 Year 2024 – United Nations General Assembly resolution

In 2024, the Czech Republic actively supported the United Nations General Assembly resolution designating July 11 as the “International Day of Remembrance for the Victims of the Srebrenica Genocide” (United Nations General Assembly, 2024).

The European Union also supported this resolution (Stojanovic, 2024). The resolution received votes from 84 countries, including 23 of the 27 EU member states. Hungary voted against the resolution, while Greece, Slovakia, and Cyprus abstained (Turčalo, 2024).

A significant point raised by the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina (personal communication, April 2025) was that in 2024, the Czech Republic supported the United Nations resolution on the remembrance of the Srebrenica genocide. He pointed out that the European Union lacks unity on this issue, because Hungary opposed the resolution, aligning itself with Russia and Belarus, while the Slovak government currently holds a position that does not reflect the EU's mainstream approach to genocide remembrance. This division reveals a broader problem within the EU in achieving a consistent stance on historical justice and human rights.

The Head of Memorial Center Srebrenica - Potočari (email communication, April 2025) expressed strong support for the UN General Assembly resolution and noted that Mark Rutte, who held the office of Dutch Prime Minister at the time and is now NATO Secretary General, visited the Memorial Center last year.

8.5 Recognition of genocide

On July 11, 2005, the Czech Republic officially recognized the Srebrenica massacre as genocide. In their message, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs cited clear evidence of genocidal acts, emphasized the necessity of confronting past crimes, and called on political leaders in Bosnia and the wider region to reject the human rights violations and ideologies that led to the violence of the 1990s. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005)

The European Union has regularly spoken out about the legacy of Srebrenica, especially through the actions of the European Parliament and the European Commission. In 2009, the European Parliament passed a resolution that officially acknowledged the July 1995 as the "European Day of Remembrance for the Victims of the Srebrenica Genocide" (European Parliament, 2009). The resolution encouraged all EU member states and countries in the Western Balkans to observe the day officially, emphasizing that reconciliation is essential for progress toward European integration. It also urged political leaders in the region to confront their past honestly and support open dialogue as a foundation for lasting peace. (Dragović-Soso, 2012)

8.6 International criminal courts

According to a researcher at the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law, University of Sarajevo (email communication, April 2025), the recognition of the Srebrenica genocide by international courts represents a crucial step toward justice and confronting the past. This is especially meaningful for the victims' families. Serbia remains the only country judged by an international court for failing to prevent the genocide. Complete reconciliation, the researcher stressed, requires all parties to recognize the genocide and accept historical facts.

Czechia has steadily backed the efforts of international criminal courts, such as the ICTY and the ICC, considering international justice a key pillar of its foreign policy (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2017). Czech leaders regularly reaffirm their commitment to

international humanitarian law and the principles of accountability. For example, in a 2022 address to the Assembly of States Parties, Foreign Minister Jan Lipavský described the ICC as “irreplaceable” in the fight against impunity, highlighting that atrocities such as those committed during Russia’s aggression in Ukraine only reinforce the need for justice. (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2022b)

Czechia has also demonstrated long-term financial support for international criminal justice. Since 2011, it has contributed to the ICC’s Trust Fund for Victims, increasing its voluntary financial contribution of CZK 1,000,000 (around EUR 40,000) in 2024 to support reparations and victim assistance programs. (International Criminal Court, 2024)

Similarly, the European Union actively supported the ICTY and the ICC, through political endorsement and direct financial contributions. In December 2000, the European Union contributed up to EUR 1,482,313 to the Voluntary Fund of the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia (ICTY). This support contributed to funding the Tribunal’s Outreach Programme, the ICTY Library, and training for defence lawyers, helping to build the court’s capacity and improve its connection with the public. (International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia, 2000)

According to the Head of the Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari (email communication, April 2025), it is essential to hold war criminals accountable. Bosnia and Herzegovina still faces serious challenges due to the continued influence of followers of convicted war criminals Ratko Mladić and Radovan Karadžić, who are now trying to achieve their wartime goals in different ways. He also said that the European Union should increase its support for the victims and take a firmer stance in condemning the perpetrators and their sympathizers, particularly in Republika Srpska and Serbia.

8.7 Education and memory

A notable divergence between the Czech Republic and the EU stands in the EU’s more systematic and institutionalized involvement in educational and preventive initiatives related to genocide and mass atrocities. The EU supports initiatives like Erasmus+ and the Jean Monnet Modules, which focus on education around European values, human rights, and historical memory. Bosnia and Herzegovina is often included as a partner in these programs,

helping to foster reconciliation and raising awareness across the Western Balkans over the long term. (European Commission, n.d.)

Another example of the EU's coordinated approach is its backing of the Genocide Network under Eurojust. The network supports cooperation among EU member states in investigating and prosecuting genocide, crimes against humanity, and war crimes. It encourages the exchange of knowledge, legal resources, and effective practices to strengthen accountability. The Genocide Network has also dealt with crimes from the former Yugoslavia, including those committed in Srebrenica. (Genocide Network Secretariat, 2014)

The European Union also supports the remembrance of the Srebrenica genocide through financial assistance to the Srebrenica Memorial Center. As part of a broader project, the EU Delegation in Bosnia and Herzegovina funded the reconstruction of the archive building, the renovation of administrative facilities, and the construction of a new visitor center (Head of Memorial Center in Srebrenica – Potočari, email communication, April 2025).

In addition to infrastructure support, the EU contributes to educational outreach. As the Head of the Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari noted (email communication, April 2025), “EU countries regularly visit the Srebrenica Memorial Center. Students come from the Netherlands, Germany, Austria, Belgium, Sweden, Denmark, and Italy. There is growing interest from students in other countries who are writing theses on the topic of the Srebrenica genocide.”

While the Czech Republic does not have a comparable institutional framework, it contributes to genocide education and memory through academic engagement. The Czech Academy of Sciences actively researches genocide prevention and transitional justice and participates in international events on these topics. For instance, its scholars have participated in conferences exploring the legacy of the Srebrenica genocide and its implications for memory culture and post-conflict healing. (Yale MacMillan Center Genocide Studies Program, 2020)

According to the Head of the Srebrenica Memorial Center – Potočari (email communication, April 2025), several Czech academics have taken steps to engage with the topic of the Srebrenica genocide, including plans to formalize cooperation through a Memorandum of Understanding with professors from the University of Plzeň. In addition, Czech students have visited the Memorial Center through European exchange programs. The respondent

emphasized that the Center is open to collaborating with Czech professors, universities, and schools by providing access to its resources and expertise to support genocide education.

Furthermore, the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina (personal communication, April 2025) stated that the Czech Embassy is working to establish cooperation with the Lidice Memorial, and to launch a project focused on preserving the oral history of the Srebrenica genocide. This step would mark an important way for Czechia to honor the memory of Srebrenica. Still, the Deputy Ambassador expressed doubt that the genocide will ever be taught in schools as prominently as the Holocaust, highlighting the continued need to keep its memory alive through education and public awareness.

However, research initiatives from the Czech Republic in this area remain limited compared to those of other EU countries. As noted by a researcher at the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law, University of Sarajevo (email communication, April 2025), the author of this thesis was the first Czech national to visit the Institute: “Until now, as far as I know, and I have been working at the Institute for 16 years, we have not had any persons (politicians, diplomats, researchers, students) from the Czech Republic visit the Institute.” In contrast, the Institute has hosted numerous scientists, researchers, academics, and students from across Europe and regularly welcomes students pursuing master’s and doctoral research.

Figure 5: Comparative analysis of Czechia and EU's positions on Srebrenica genocide

Category / Year	Czech Republic	European Union	Alignment
1995 – Srebrenica massacre	Initial reaction via the UN, participation of Kovanda in the UN Security Council, rather reserved	Inadequate response, strong criticism for passivity	Both sides were rather passive, weak response
2005 – 10th anniversary of the genocide	Official recognition as genocide, statements from MFA and the President	Recognition of the tragedy, not officially as a genocide	Strong alignment, Czechia stronger response
2015 – 20th anniversary of the genocide	Hamáček visited Srebrenica, parliament honored victims, Zaorálek called for justice	EP condemned of the genocide, solidarity with victims, regret UN failure, Borrell rejected genocide denial	Joint diplomatic and symbolic participation
2024 – UN General Assembly resolution	Czech Republic voted for the resolution on International Remembrance Day	EU supported the resolution, not united response	High level of alignment
Recognition of Genocide	Officially recognized since 2005	Recognized by the European Parliament since 2009, systematic	The EU was more consistent, Czechia sooner recognition
International Criminal Courts	Support for ICTY and ICC	EU actively finances ICTY, supports ICC	Both supports, but the EU is more systematic
Education and Memory	Still mostly symbolic, engagement of the Czech Academy of Sciences	Programs like Erasmus+, Jean Monnet, Genocide Network	EU more active in prevention and education

Source: own elaboration

FINDINGS

The thesis aimed to analyze the foreign policy of the Czech Republic on genocide, with a specific focus on the Srebrenica genocide. Based on the research conducted, the author is presenting these findings:

The main research question, which examined the development of the Czech Republic's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide between 1995 and 2025, shows that the Czech Republic's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide evolved from initial uncertainty to a strong commitment to recognition, justice, and remembrance. Between 1995 and 1999, there was some hesitation and partial denial regarding the full extent of the Srebrenica massacre, however, by 1999, the Czech Republic supported NATO's intervention in the Balkans to prevent further genocides. In 2005, on the tenth anniversary of the massacre, the Czech Republic officially recognized the atrocity as genocide. It urged political leaders in the region to condemn past abuses of human rights. In the 2010s, the Czech Republic's perception of the Srebrenica genocide shifted toward active support for regional reconciliation and closer alignment with the European Union's approach. Czech political discourse firmly rejected any denial of the Srebrenica genocide, and the Czech Republic welcomed the decisions of international criminal courts. Between 2020 and 2024, Czech foreign policy remained focused on the importance of remembrance and concrete action. At the time, high-ranking Czech representatives visited the Srebrenica Memorial Center to honor the victims and address the ongoing issue of genocide denial. The year 2024 stood out, as Czechia supported a United Nations General Assembly resolution commemorating the Srebrenica genocide.

The analysis of the first additional research question examined historical, political, and international factors that influenced the Czech Republic's perception and diplomatic approach to the Srebrenica genocide. The findings demonstrate that historically, Czechia's own experiences with totalitarian regimes and its tradition of democratic and humanistic values, shaped by key milestones such as the legacy of Tomáš Garrigue Masaryk, the Prague Spring, and Charter 77, instilled a strong moral imperative in its foreign policy, particularly regarding human rights and mass atrocities. The legacy of Czech humanism, Soviet oppression, and early post-communist idealism created fertile ground for principled positions on genocide prevention. Politically, the leadership of Václav Havel played a foundational role in setting a

human rights centered tone in the 1990s, at the same time, later governments slowly made commemoration part of official practice, especially during important anniversaries of the genocide. Although later leaders like Miloš Zeman were less engaged, recent figures such as President Petr Pavel reaffirmed Czechia's proactive, values-driven foreign policy. Internationally, Czechia's close ties with major Western institutions like the United Nations, NATO, and the European Union shaped its approach and gave it a platform for diplomatic action. Through its support for UN resolutions, involvement in NATO peacekeeping, and alignment with EU policies on justice and reconciliation, Czechia has made it clear that it sees Srebrenica as genocide and stands behind efforts to remember the victims and seek accountability. These actions reflect a real shift in its foreign policy, from uncertainty in the early years to a more grounded, principled stance built on responsibility, solidarity, and a commitment to human rights.

The analysis of the second additional research question, which examined the extent of alignment between EU and Czech policies, revealed a strong alignment in their approaches to the Srebrenica genocide, particularly from the mid-2000s onward. Both recognized the genocide, condemned denial, supported transitional justice, and promoted reconciliation in the Western Balkans. Czechia even took a slightly earlier and more precise stance in 2005 by officially recognizing the massacre as genocide, preceding the EU's formal recognition in 2009. Since then, Czech foreign policy has largely mirrored the EU's, notably in supporting the ICTY and ICC, and in conditioning Serbia's EU accession on cooperation with international justice. However, minor differences persist - the EU has developed more comprehensive institutional mechanisms for education and prevention, such as the Erasmus+ programme and the Genocide Network. In contrast, Czech efforts in these areas are more ad hoc and often driven by individual institutions like the Czech Academy of Sciences rather than being part of a coordinated national strategy.

DISCUSSION

This thesis has explored how the Czech Republic's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide developed over the thirty years from 1995 to 2025. The evidence clearly shows a shift, from early diplomatic hesitation to stronger engagement and increasing alignment with international norms, particularly those promoted by the European Union. This transformation took time and was shaped by Czechia's own history, the decisions of its political leaders, and its expanding role in international institutions.

Right after the genocide in 1995, Czech diplomacy was still relatively young, shaped by post-communist transitions and lacking deep strategic interest in the Balkans. However, there were signs of moral clarity, even at this early stage. Ambassador Karel Kovanda stood out at the UN Security Council by being one of the first to call the Rwanda atrocities "genocide" and by criticizing the major powers for staying silent (Kovanda, 2010). This same moral concern carried over into the Czech reaction to Srebrenica. Kovanda co-sponsored Resolution 1019 and directly addressed the massacre, comparing it to the UN's failure in Rwanda (United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, 2015). These actions showed that Czechia was already willing to speak up for international justice, even when its institutional capacity was still limited.

The real turning point came in 2005, when the Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs officially recognized the Srebrenica massacre as genocide. In its statement, the Ministry called it "the worst single atrocity in Europe since World War II." It encouraged Bosnian leaders to reject nationalist ideologies and take responsibility for past crimes (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Czech Republic, 2005). This was a clear sign that Czech foreign policy had moved beyond symbolic gestures and was starting to adopt a stronger, more principled stance grounded in international law, especially the ICTY and ICJ rulings.

This position became more visible in the years that followed. In 2015, the Czech Republic supported the European Parliament's resolution condemning the denial of the Srebrenica genocide and joined EU commemorations (European Parliament, 2017). Foreign Minister Lubomír Zaorálek emphasized the importance of memory and justice, while Speaker of Parliament Jan Hamáček attended the memorial ceremony in Potočari (Institute of International Relations, 2015). These gestures weren't just about expressing solidarity, they showed that remembering the past can help shape how a country approaches foreign policy. This thesis finds

that Czech diplomacy in the 2010s and 2020s began to place more value on symbolic actions, education, and support for reconciliation as part of its broader international role. Field research confirmed that Czech representatives regularly visit the Srebrenica Memorial Center and actively support local initiatives, such as the House of Good Tones, which provides educational opportunities for children in Srebrenica (personal visit to Srebrenica Memorial Center, April 2025; personal communication with Deputy Ambassador, April 2025). Even if these steps aren't large-scale, they have an impact, they reflect Czechia's ongoing effort to stand with those affected by war and to support the long, difficult process of healing.

It's also important to recognize that Czech foreign policy on this issue has sometimes been shaped by domestic politics. While figures like Václav Havel and Petr Pavel pushed for a values-driven approach, others didn't always share the same vision or priorities. For instance, President Miloš Zeman's decision to skip the 2015 Srebrenica commemoration stood in contrast to the steady involvement of other Czech institutions (Institute of International Relations, 2015). This kind of inconsistency shows how changes in leadership can make it difficult to keep foreign policy on a steady, long-term path.

Most recently, Czechia's support for the 2024 UN General Assembly resolution on Srebrenica confirmed its continued alignment with EU priorities and international legal standards (United Nations General Assembly, 2024). Based on the interviews carried out for this thesis, Czech officials and experts viewed this vote as a chance to reinforce both their country's moral stance and its position as a committed EU member (personal communications, April 2025).

Interviews conducted for this research further illustrate how Czech foreign policy gradually aligned with the broader EU discourse. The Deputy Ambassador to Bosnia and Herzegovina confirmed that Czechia actively supports Bosnia's path to EU membership and views confronting history as a key part of that process (personal communication, April 2025). Mr. Azir Osmanović from the Srebrenica Memorial Center pointed to the ongoing cooperation with Czech diplomats and mentioned that they regularly attend commemoration events (email communication, April 2025). Similarly, Professor Ermin Kuka noted the growing academic interest from the Czech Republic and stressed how vital education is in keeping cultural memory alive (email communication, April 2025).

A noticeable similarity appears, when comparing Czech and EU responses, especially from 2005 onward. Like the EU, the Czech Republic has backed international justice mechanisms and supported symbolic recognition of the genocide (Eurojust, 2014). However, as shown in Chapter 8.7, Czechia still lacks some of the more structured and institutionalized frameworks in EU programs, such as the Genocide Network or coordinated educational efforts. These facts show that even though Czech policy lines up with the right principles, there's still work to be done when it comes to putting those principles into practice.

Nevertheless, this study has several important limitations. It focuses on a single country and one specific case of genocide, narrowing its focus both geographically and thematically. While the qualitative approach helped shed light on how Czech foreign policy developed, it also means the findings can't be easily applied to other cases. The author also wasn't able to access certain key sources, like classified diplomatic communications, which likely made it harder to go deeper in some parts of the analysis. In addition, the research relies mainly on publicly available materials, which don't always capture internal discussions or differing views within government institutions.

Future research could build on this study by addressing some of its limitations. One possible direction would be to compare how other Central and Eastern European countries have approached the Srebrenica genocide in their foreign policies. Expanding the analysis in this way could offer a broader regional perspective. More fieldwork, especially conversations with policymakers and diplomats who were directly involved, could offer a clearer look into the thinking and decisions that drove the changes explored in this thesis. It would also be worth looking at how the Czech Republic has viewed the Srebrenica genocide over the years, how the media has covered it, and whether those public and media narratives have played a role in shaping foreign policy decisions.

CONCLUSION

To sum up, this thesis has explored how Czechia's foreign policy toward the Srebrenica genocide developed between 1995 and 2025, moving from initial caution to a more consistent, principled position based on recognition, justice, and remembrance and influenced by its own historical experience with Soviet influence and by figures like Václav Havel, Czechia gradually aligned with European Union norms on human rights and transitional justice. The research highlights how national memory politics, domestic leadership, and international obligations, primarily through the UN and NATO, have shaped Czech diplomatic discourse. It also highlights the continued importance of challenging denial and supporting education and remembrance to uphold historical accountability.

Czechia's experience shows that even a small post-communist country can play a meaningful role in shaping global conversations about justice and moral responsibility. While its foreign policy has become more consistent and ethically grounded, moments of political ambivalence have exposed underlying tensions between values and domestic politics. Still, Czechia's engagement with Srebrenica shows that even smaller EU countries can play a meaningful role in advancing international justice and memory, building credibility, and demonstrating a genuine commitment to upholding international law.

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Appendix A: Interview with the Director of the Memorial Center Srebrenica - Potočari, Azir Osmanović

What is the core mission and vision of the Srebrenica Memorial Center?

“The Memorial Center is a place of remembrance for the victims of the Srebrenica genocide of 1995 and is dedicated to preserving history and confronting the forces of ignorance and hatred that lead to genocide. Through various activities and projects we implement, we aim to highlight the importance of learning about genocide and preventing all forms of violence in the world.”

What challenges is the Memorial Center currently facing in fulfilling its mission?

“We are currently facing numerous challenges. The first is the security and political situation in Bosnia and Herzegovina, along with the desire of followers of convicted war criminals Ratko Mladić and Radovan Karadžić to achieve their wartime goals—though now in a different way. The fact that the Srebrenica Memorial Center is located in the Republika Srpska entity, while being a state institution, makes us a frequent target of that entity’s authorities. This is our number one challenge.”

What are the main challenges in preserving the memory of the genocide in today’s political climate?

“There are many challenges. The support of the international community in Bosnia and Herzegovina is key. This shows that genocide deniers are simply waiting for the right moment to rewrite history and impose their own narrative.”

Do you collaborate in any way with the Czech Republic, for example through its embassy or cultural events?

“As far as I know, we have not had any significant cooperation with the Czech Republic. However, it is encouraging that there is currently a wonderful ambassador representing the Czech Republic in Bosnia and Herzegovina. I don’t doubt that previous ambassadors were good as well. This ambassador has visited the Srebrenica Memorial Center three times in the past year. We have discussed various topics and potential cooperation. I hope we will soon see concrete results. Just two weeks ago, I hosted professors from the University of Plzeň on an official visit. We are planning to formalize our cooperation through a Memorandum of

Understanding. I've also noticed a greater presence of Czech representatives within the EU Delegation and EUFOR in Bosnia and Herzegovina, so there is a lot of room for collaboration."

Are you aware of any Czech schools or universities that have visited the Memorial Center?

"I am not sure that any organized school or university visits have taken place. However, students studying in the Czech Republic through various student exchange programs have visited."

Have any Czech politicians or diplomatic representatives visited the Memorial Center?

If so, when and in what context?

"About a month ago, a high-level Czech delegation visited Srebrenica. The President of the Czech Parliament, Mrs. Markéta Pekarová Adamová, visited the Memorial Center. Other members of the delegation included: Vladimír Zlínský, Member of the Chamber of Deputies of the Czech Parliament; Martin Plíšek, Head of the Office of the Chamber of Deputies; Zdeněk Běránek, Foreign Policy Advisor to the President; Martin Churaví, Press Secretary; and Václav Agh, Media Advisor. President Pekarová Adamová and the delegation attended a meeting with Mrs. Amra Begić, Assistant Director of the Memorial Center, and members of the associations of genocide victims' families. During the visit, they discussed the importance of preserving the memory of the genocide and the effort to ensure that the truth is never forgotten. After the meeting, the delegation visited the cemetery to pay tribute to the victims by laying a wreath, demonstrating their solidarity and respect for the victims and survivors. The visit by the President of the Parliament and the Czech delegation confirmed the importance of international cooperation in preserving truth, justice, and human rights."

How do you perceive the Czech Republic's stance on the Srebrenica genocide, and how

has it evolved over the years?

"To my knowledge, the Czech Republic voted in favor of the resolution on the Srebrenica genocide adopted by the United Nations General Assembly last year. This confirms that the Czech government has chosen the side of truth and justice. The visit of your country's diplomats to the Srebrenica Memorial Center is further evidence that you acknowledge the genocide, which has been internationally recognized by court rulings."

How would you evaluate the diplomatic activities of the Czech Embassy in Bosnia and Herzegovina regarding the genocide?

“As I mentioned earlier, you have a wonderful ambassador in Bosnia and Herzegovina, and we feel her support. We hope this continues and that we will develop concrete projects in the future aimed at educating younger generations in the Czech Republic about the genocide in Srebrenica.”

In your opinion, what role should the Czech Republic play in promoting awareness and education about the genocide, both domestically and internationally?

“Given the Czech Republic's geopolitical position, I believe that awareness and education about genocide in your country should be more prominent for several reasons. The Srebrenica Memorial Center plans to launch various educational activities in the future, and we are willing to offer Czech professors, universities, and schools access to some of our tools and knowledge to support genocide education.”

Do you collaborate in any way with EU countries, for example through their embassies or cultural events?

“Yes. We have the support of many embassies in Bosnia and Herzegovina and their agencies. Some of our most important projects have been funded by the EU Delegation in Bosnia and Herzegovina, as well as the embassies of the Netherlands, United Kingdom, USA, Turkey, and others.”

Are you aware of any schools or universities from EU member states that have visited the Memorial Center as part of educational programs? If so, which countries are they from?

“Yes. We have students from various EU countries and from around the world—especially from the United States—who regularly visit the Srebrenica Memorial Center. Students come from the Netherlands, Germany, Austria, Belgium, Sweden, Denmark, Italy, and more. There is growing interest from students in other countries who are writing theses on the topic of the Srebrenica genocide.”

Have EU politicians or diplomatic representatives visited the Memorial Center?

“Yes. During official visits to Bosnia and Herzegovina, some political representatives also visit the Srebrenica Memorial Center. For example, last year, Mark Rutte, then Prime Minister of the Netherlands and now NATO Secretary General, visited the Center. Ministers and

parliamentarians from several countries often include the Memorial Center in their itineraries while in Bosnia and Herzegovina.”

How would you describe the European Union’s stance on the Srebrenica genocide?

“All UN member states, except Hungary, have a fair stance regarding the Srebrenica genocide. However, that stance could be clearer and more direct—especially following the adoption of the resolution at the UN General Assembly last year. The EU must offer more support to the victims and more strongly condemn the perpetrators and their followers, especially those in Republika Srpska and Serbia.”

Which EU countries contribute the most to preserving the memory of the Srebrenica genocide, and how does their approach differ from that of the Czech Republic?

“Italy, for example, because we receive the largest number of EU visitors from there. The Netherlands also contributes significantly by funding numerous projects aimed at preserving the culture of remembrance.”

Do you cooperate with EU institutions (such as the European Parliament or the European Commission) in preserving the memory of the genocide?

“Not directly, but we do work with EU institutions through their offices and delegations in Bosnia and Herzegovina.”

Have any projects or activities been implemented in Srebrenica that were funded by the EU? If so, can you share specific examples?

“The reconstruction of the archive building at the Memorial Center, as well as part of a project involving the renovation of the administrative building and the construction of a visitor center, were funded by the EU Delegation in Bosnia and Herzegovina.”

In 2025, we mark 30 years since the genocide. Do you expect increased interest or involvement from the EU and its member states?

“In addition to the commemoration at the Memorial Center in Potočari, the anniversary will be marked in other countries as well. I know there will be a commemoration in the European Parliament. These events across Europe typically attract large numbers of people. That will certainly be the case this year, especially since it is the 30th anniversary.”

Are there Czech visitors to the Memorial Center, including students or researchers? How many visit each year?

“Unfortunately, the number is small. I don’t have exact figures. I would like to see more, and I hope that will be the case in the future.”

Do visitors from EU member states come to the Srebrenica Memorial Center? If so, approximately how many visit each year, and which EU countries are most represented?

“We receive a considerable number of visitors. The most frequent visitors from the EU come from Italy, Germany, the Netherlands, and Croatia.”

Appendix B: Interview with the Deputy Ambassador of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina, Ing. Josef Zrzavecký

What is the official policy of the Czech Republic to Bosnia and Herzegovina?

The respondent stated that The Czech Republic's foreign policy towards Bosnia and Herzegovina today is primarily shaped by its broader focus on the Middle East and Ukraine, while still maintaining a strong commitment to supporting stability in the Balkan region. Deputy Ambassador also mentioned that the Czech Republic actively promotes the European integration of Bosnia and Herzegovina, notably through its participation in the Group of Friends of the Western Balkans, alongside Austria, Italy, Slovakia, Slovenia, Greece, Croatia, and others. As part of a coalition of seven countries dedicated to regional stability, the Czech Republic advocates for accelerating the EU integration process of Western Balkan states. Its foreign policy emphasizes human rights, democratic transformation, historical justice, and regional peace. In support of these goals, the Czech Embassy in Sarajevo is currently preparing a water management project specifically targeted at the municipality of Srebrenica. Czech troops also remain present in Bosnia and Herzegovina, contributing to international peacekeeping efforts. Furthermore, the Czech Embassy is developing cooperation with the Lidice Memorial in the Czech Republic, aiming to launch a project focused on preserving the oral memory of the Srebrenica genocide.

What is the position of the Czech Republic regarding the Srebrenica genocide, and how has this position evolved from 1995 to 2025?

The Czech Republic participates annually in the commemoration ceremonies in Srebrenica, usually represented by a member of the government or a senior delegation. In the past year, a Deputy Ambassador attended the memorial events. In 2024, the Czech Republic supported the United Nations resolution on the remembrance and reflection of the Srebrenica genocide. According to the Deputy Ambassador, "Srebrenica is a symbol that must never be repeated." Czech political figures, such as the Speaker of the Chamber of Deputies Markéta Pekarová Adamová, have also contributed to honoring the memory of the victims through official visits. The Deputy Ambassador emphasized that the memorial significance of Srebrenica is essential for collective remembrance, similarly to the memory of the Holocaust. However, there is skepticism about whether the Srebrenica genocide will ever be taught in schools as widely as

the Holocaust. The representative stressed that "what is forgotten, will be repeated," highlighting the critical role of remembrance. He further underlined that genocide must be recognized as a grave crime regardless of the number of victims, emphasizing that the decisive factor is the intent to destroy a national group.

How does cooperation with international institutions influence regional dynamics in post-conflict Bosnia and Herzegovina?

The Czech Republic has demonstrated its commitment to post-war societal reconstruction through cooperation between Czech Ministry of Foreign Affairs officials and the Office of the High Representative (OHR) on issues of reconciliation in Bosnia and Herzegovina. In reflecting on broader European integration processes, the situation regarding Croatia's accession to the European Union—particularly its efforts to confront and address its wartime past—was compared by a Czech diplomat to the Czech Republic's own experience in resolving the Temelín nuclear power dispute with Austria. In previous years, the Netherlands had insisted on Bosnia and Herzegovina's full cooperation with the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia (ICTY) as a precondition for progress towards EU membership. The processes of confronting the past, prosecuting war crimes, and improving relations with neighboring states are seen as essential steps for Bosnia and Herzegovina's successful integration into the European Union. However, the diplomat noted that opinions among EU member states on Bosnia's accession remain divided, and emphasized that the Czech Republic should work to strengthen and clearly articulate its position within the European framework.

What's the social and ethnic context of Srebrenica?

Srebrenica is located within the territory of Republika Srpska, an entity of Bosnia and Herzegovina where political tension remains present to this day. The Srebrenica Memorial Center and the commemoration of the genocide exist in a region governed by authorities who have consistently shown resistance or denial toward the recognition of the 1995 atrocity. Many members of the "Mothers of Srebrenica"—women who lost up to 17 family members—continue to live near the memorial gravesites, yet without experiencing genuine acknowledgment from the local administration. Despite attempts at ethnic homogenization during and after the war, Srebrenica remains a multiethnic town and not exclusively Serb. According to a Czech diplomat, the genocide was deliberately carried out as a method of ethnic extermination specifically targeting the Bosniak population. Each year, a multiday Peace

March is held, retracing in reverse the path of the 1995 escape route, serving as both a tribute to the victims and a powerful reminder of the atrocity's human toll.

How would you comment the Czech and EU position on Un General Assembly Resolution in 2024?

In 2024, the Czech Republic supported the United Nations resolution on the remembrance of the Srebrenica genocide. Nevertheless, the European Union has shown a certain lack of unity on this issue, as Hungary sided with Russia and Belarus in opposing the resolution. Similarly, the Slovak government is currently "not in the mainstream of the EU" regarding its position on genocide remembrance. As noted by a diplomat, "We do not yet know how the Czech Republic will position itself regarding the new UN resolution on the commemoration of the genocide; it will be interesting to observe its development compared to other states."

What are the cultural and educational activities of the Czech Republic regarding the Srebrenica genocide?

The Czech Republic has supported the cultural and educational project "House of Good Tones" (Dům dobrých tónů) in Srebrenica, a center dedicated to providing artistic and educational activities for children and youth. This initiative represents an important effort to foster post-conflict recovery and multicultural dialogue. There is hope that in the future, the Srebrenica genocide will be taught and remembered in schools in the same way as the Holocaust. However, there remains a degree of skepticism regarding whether Srebrenica will truly become an integrated part of official history education curricula. The Deputy Ambassador disclosed that a collaboration with a Czech museum is underway, aiming to create an exhibition about the Srebrenica genocide, which represents an important step toward strengthening the Czech nation's memory for the future.

Appendix C: Interview with an academic from the Institute for Research of Crimes Against Humanity and International Law, Prof. dr. Ermin Kuka

Could you briefly describe the main research and educational activities of your Institute, particularly in relation to the Srebrenica genocide?

“The Institute's primary activity is the scientific research of all forms of crimes against humanity and international law, including the crime of genocide committed during the aggression against the Republic of Bosnia and Herzegovina from 1992 to 1995. In their work so far, the Institute's scientists and researchers have devoted a special focus to the scientific research of the crime of genocide committed against Bosniaks in the UN "safe zone" of Srebrenica in July 1995. In this regard, the Institute has organized dozens of international scientific conferences, forums, round tables, lectures and seminars dedicated to the genocide against Bosniaks in Srebrenica in July 1995. In the last 10 years alone, conferences have been organized every year. Many of them were also held in Potočari (Srebrenica). Also, within the framework of its publishing activities, the Institute has published dozens of scientific books, studies, as well as scientific and professional articles in journals and collections of works, both in Bosnia and Herzegovina and abroad, on the topic of the genocide against Bosniaks in Srebrenica. Even today, the Institute devotes great attention to studying the subject matter, and has made a great contribution to the development and operationalization of the idea of adopting the Resolution on Srebrenica in the UN General Assembly.”

From your institutional perspective, how important is international recognition of the Srebrenica genocide in countering denial and promoting reconciliation in Bosnia and Herzegovina?

“International recognition and internationally adjudicated crime of genocide against Bosniaks in Srebrenica represents a major step forward for justice and facing the past. It is especially significant for the families of those killed in the genocide, because the highest judicial instances in the world have ruled that it was an intent to destroy the national group (Bosniaks) in Srebrenica by the political leadership and military leadership, the army of Republika Srpska and the Ministry of Internal Affairs of Republika Srpska, as well as numerous other military formations, including foreign and volunteer military formations (Russians, Greeks, Ukrainians, etc.). There is also the role of neighboring Serbia (then the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia). I

would like to remind you that Serbia is the only country in the world that has been judged by the International Criminal Court to have failed to prevent the genocide against Bosniaks in Srebrenica in July 1995, but could have. There can be no complete reconciliation until all parties recognize the verdicts and established historical facts. The adoption of the Resolution represents a major and significant fact, and is an important form of the fight against the ever-present narrative of falsification and revitalization of historical facts and the fight against genocide deniers.”

Do you recall any Czech academics, students, or diplomats visiting your Institute for research, internships, or commemorative events?

“Until now, as far as I know, and I have been working at the Institute for 16 years, we have not had any persons (politicians, diplomats, researchers, students) from the Czech Republic visit the Institute.”

Has your Institute collaborated with Czech government bodies on projects related to Srebrenica genocide?

“As far as I know, not directly. It is possible that there was indirect communication, but I don't know specifically.”

What role do you believe official visits from foreign delegations—such as Czech parliamentarians—to the Srebrenica Memorial Center or your Institute play in promoting justice and remembrance?

“The role of visits by foreign delegations, among whom are often parliamentarians, to the Srebrenica-Potočati Memorial Center is very important. It is a significant sign and a step forward and an opportunity for all of them to personally, through their presence, see the extent of the crime of genocide committed against Bosniaks. In this way, even after a personal visit, they can find out the facts and the truth for themselves, without someone else imposing their opinion on them, especially those who deny the genocide, and on the other hand, have never deigned to visit the Memorial Center and the cemetery of the victims of genocide. Such visits are also important because they spread the truth to new generations of young people who were not even born when it happened.”

Do you think Czech participation in international commemorative events, such as July 11th anniversaries, meaningfully contributes to both local and international memory culture?

“Absolutely. Such forms of participation and participation of the Czech Republic are important for preserving the collective culture of memory and spreading a clear message that such evil will never happen again to anyone in the world. The position of the Czech Republic on these issues and its vote for the adoption of the Resolution on Srebrenica in the UN General Assembly, as well as the organization of commemorations every July 11 of the year, are worthy of praise and respect.”

Have you hosted researchers, students, or academics from other EU countries?

“Yes. We have hosted numerous scientists, researchers, academics and students from many countries, both from Europe and from all over the world. The international conferences we have organized have been attended by numerous scientists and researchers from America, Canada, Venezuela, Rwanda, Tunisia, Germany, France, Belgium, the Netherlands, Turkey, Great Britain, Italy, etc. We also receive numerous students who are doing their master's and doctoral research. This is evident throughout the year and we are very much looking forward to such student visits and research.”

Has your Institute collaborated with EU on projects related to Srebrenica genocide?

“Indirectly, through the Memorial Center and other organizations, as part of a research network of organizations and institutions. We did not have the opportunity to be a direct participant in any of the EU projects.”

Is your Institute currently involved in any EU-funded projects (e.g., Horizon Europe, Erasmus+, Jean Monnet), and have Czech institutions participated as partners in these initiatives?

“No. We are not currently.”

What specific recommendations would you offer to countries like the Czech Republic or EU member states for strengthening their engagement with post-conflict societies through justice, remembrance, and academic cooperation?

“It is certainly best for them to work on developing and supporting programs and projects that concern the development of a culture of remembrance of events that befell societies that were affected by conflict, or post-conflict societies. These projects and programs should include various forms and types of education, the organization of seminars and other forms of lectures at universities and scientific institutions (for example, in the Czech Republic), where scientists and researchers who deal with, for example, the genocide in Srebrenica, as well as surviving witnesses, would be invited as lecturers and presenters. They should also be involved in publishing projects as a form of combating the denial of crimes. There are a number of other forms of participation and contribution in this area.”